

THE TOUR OF MONT BLANC ANTI-CLOCKWISE



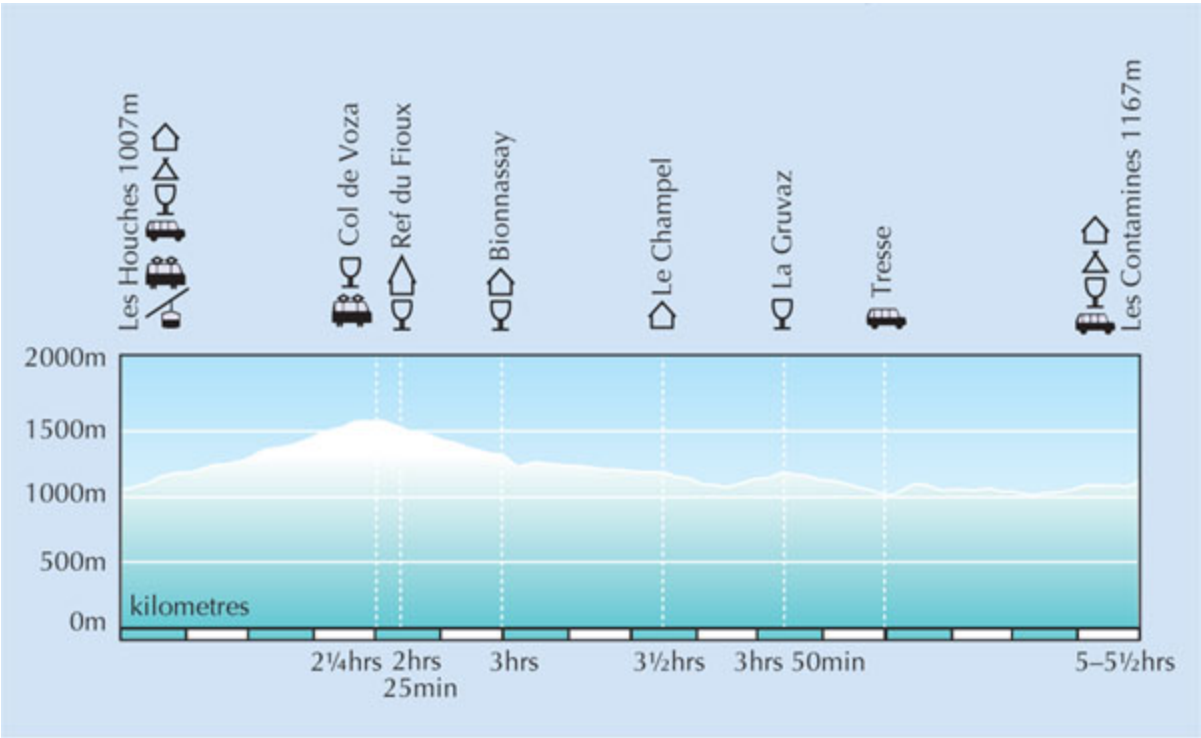
The sharply pointed Aiguille Noire de Peuterey stands spear-like above Lac Combal

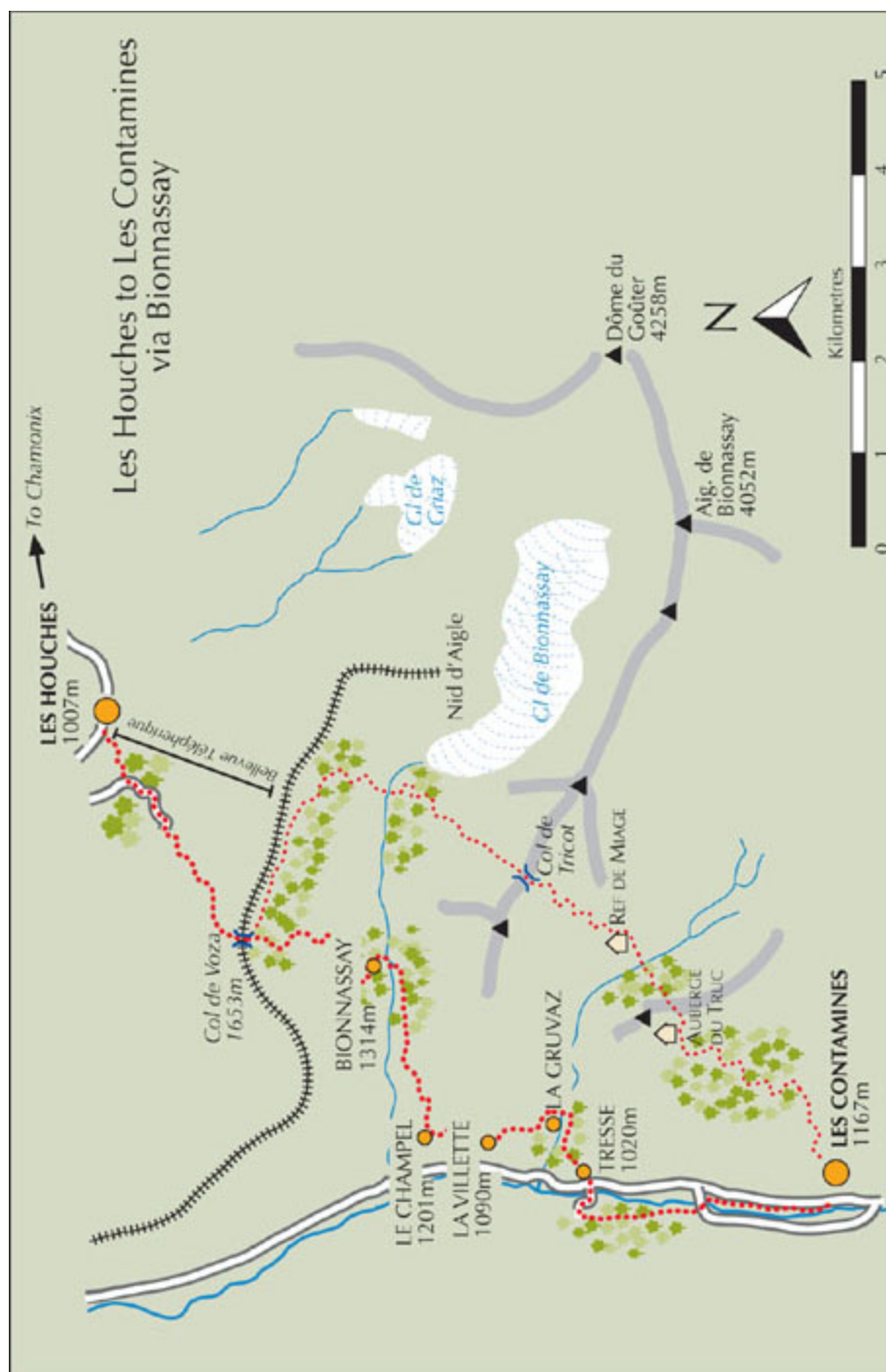
STAGE 1*Les Houches – Bionnassay – Les Contamines*

Start point	Les Houches (1007m)
Distance	16km
Height gain	646m
Height loss	633m
Time	5–5½hrs
High point	Col de Voza (1653m)
Transport options	Cableway (Les Houches – Bellevue); Cableway (Les Houches/Les Chavants – Prarion); Train (St-Gervais – Col de Voza); Bus (Tresse – Les Contamines)
Accommodation	Les Houches – hotels, dortoirs, gîte, camping; Chalet-Refuge du Fioux (2hrs 40mins) – gîte; Col de Voza (2¼–2½hrs) – hotel; Bionnassay (3hrs) – gîte; Le Champel (3½hrs) – gîte; Les Contamines – hotels, dortoirs, gîte, CAF refuge, camping
Alternative route	Col de Voza – Les Contamines via Col de Tricot and Refuge de Miage (see Alternative Stage 1)

Of the two possible routes to Les Contamines-Montjoie, this is the shorter and easier. It's also recommended as the bad-weather alternative, for apart from the crossing of Col de Voza it remains fairly low and has no really exposed country to pass through. It also involves more road-walking than any other stage; but that being said, there are some fine views (weather permitting), attractive hamlets and plenty of accommodation options even before you reach Les Contamines.

Although it does not have the dramatic appeal of the alternative route, this stage is fairly straightforward but demanding enough for a first day, during which newcomers to the Alps will be able to get into their stride and, from a variety of points along the way, gain an impression of the scenic delights that promise much for the days ahead. Just before reaching Col de Voza, for example, a row of aiguilles that guard Mont Blanc offer themselves for inspection. The Dôme du Goûter and Aiguille de Bionnassay then dominate views on the south side of the col, with the impressive Bionnassay glacier spilling between them, while from the hamlet of Le Champel the whole Val Montjoie is seen ahead, with a hint of the Col du Bonhomme at its southern end.





LES HOUCHES (1) (1007m) Office de tourisme (Tel 04 50 55 50 62; info@leshouches.com; www.leshouches.com), hotels, gîte, camping; shops, restaurants, banks, ATM, PTT, railway, buses, téléphérique. Lower-priced accommodation: Chalet-Refuge Michel Fagot in centre of village, 36 dortoir places, self-catering only, open mid-Dec to end of Sept (Tel 04 50 54 42 28; info@gite-fagot.com); Gîte-Auberge le Crêt, 10 dortoir places, 7 beds, open June to end of Sept – see route details below for access (Tel 04 50 55 52 27; aubergelecret@wanadoo.fr); Hotel Les Campanules, 120 beds, open end Dec to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 54 40 71; hotel-campanules@wanadoo.fr). For a full list of hotels, contact the tourist office.

From the railway station cross the road bridge over the river l'Arve and walk uphill into Les Houches, where the tourist office is found in the heart of the village. To reach the start of the TMB continue past the tourist office heading west until you reach the valley station of the Bellevue téléphérique on the left of the road.

Walk under the road tunnel and continue up the road until you reach 'Le Grand Balcon' where a sign directs you left up steep wooden steps, then along a track. Shortly afterwards turn left up a path, then left again up a road passing some chalets.

The route is now straightforward all the way to the col. As a metalled road it winds up to the chalets of Maison-Neuve, then you fork right on a track that soon enters forest and eventually makes a hairpin at the two buildings of La Tuile (1370m), where a sign gives 55mins to the col. Refreshments are available here at the rustic Restaurant Les Vieilles Luges. The track then continues, fairly steeply in places, all the way to **Col de Voza (1653m, 2¼–2½hrs, refreshments)** with its splendid view back down into the Vallée de l'Arve flanked by a row of aiguilles. A large hotel, the Village de Vacances APAS, dominates the col, while a small bar-restaurant stands beside the line of the Tramway du Mont Blanc **(2)**.

Note If you turn right just before the col you will find, about 30mins to the northwest, the

HOTEL LE PRARION (1860m) 15 dortoir places and 19 beds; open mid-June to early Sept (Tel 04 50 47 40 07; yves@prarion.com). Access from Les Houches/Les Chavants via télécabine. A fine viewpoint.

From the col, cross the tramway line and walk ahead on a dirt road that slopes downhill between woods and open meadows from which you gain impressive views of the Dôme du Goûter, Aiguille de Bionnassay and its glacier **(3)**. About 10mins from the col come to the well-situated



Le Crozat huddles in the shadow of the Aiguille and Glacier de Bionnassay

CHALET-REFUGE DU FIOUX (1520m) accommodation, refreshments: 24 beds; open end of May to end Sept (Tel 04 50 93 52 43).

Continue down to a car park where the track becomes a metalled road. Shortly after this the buildings of Le Crozat are seen to the left, with more fine views – local goat cheese is sometimes for sale here. A few minutes later pass a buvette (La Barmette) and a café, both on the left of the road. These are the first buildings of **Bionnassay (1314m, 3hrs, accommodation, refreshments)**, a small hamlet nestling just above the narrows of the Bionnassay valley. As the road curves sharply to the right the TMB breaks away left on the Chemin des Tetras. A few paces beyond this turning stands the gîte d'étape

AUBERGE DE BIONNASSAY 20 dortoir places, 18 beds; open June to end Sept (Tel 04 50 93 45 23).

Passing a tiny chapel descend into forest to cross a pair of bridges over the thunderous Bionnassay torrent, then steeply up to a level track/dirt road where you turn right. When you eventually emerge from the forest there's a view downvalley to St-Gervais-les-Bains. Remaining high above the valley you come to **Le Champel (1201m, 3½hrs, accommodation)**, a neat hamlet of old houses and another tiny chapel with an altar made of logs. A short distance beyond the chapel, where the TMB swings left on the now metalled road, note the

GÎTE DU CHAMPEL 8 dortoir places, 34 beds; open June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 77 55; gite@champel.fr).

Wandering down the road you gain a fine view ahead along the Val Montjoie **(4)**, but at the first hairpin, leave the road and keep ahead on a track (Chemin des Chevreuils) which leads to **La Villette (1090m)**. Veer left in the village by a large water trough and follow the narrow road past chalets, farms and meadows to a minor crossroads on the edge of **La Gruvaz (3hrs 50mins)**. Turn left up a narrow track which shortcuts the road bends, and rejoin the road by some houses and another water supply. Bear left as far as a car park, where the road ends at the entrance to the Gorges de la Gruvaz. Cross the bridge spanning a torrent pouring from the unseen Glacier du Miage, and turn immediately right in front of a restaurant ([refreshments](#)) to descend a narrow, damp footpath through forest.

Leave the forest by the first houses of **Tresse** and continue down to the D902, the main road running from St-Gervais to Les Contamines (bus stop nearby). Cross directly ahead and take the Chemin du Quy across the Bon Nant river, then wind uphill to the few houses of **Le Quy**. Here a minor track leaves the road to go straight ahead past a couple of chalets before becoming a footpath. Alternating between forest and pasture the way brings you to the few farms and houses of **Les Hoches**. [Alexis Bouvard, the astronomer who discovered the planet Neptune, was born in Les Hoches. \(A sign on a building on the left gives details.\)](#) Keep ahead on a metalled road between meadows, and about 4½hrs from Les Houches come to a T-junction.

Bear left, and shortly after come to another road at a hairpin by a timber yard. Here you cross the Bon Nant river again by the Pont du Plan de Moulin, and immediately turn right on a riverside path. This is the Sentier de Val Montjoie, which remains among trees and makes a very pleasant approach to Les Contamines. A little under 20mins along this path it forks. If you plan to find accommodation at the CAF's refuge, continue ahead for 15mins, otherwise take the left branch which angles up the slope and brings you into the heart of **Les Contamines-Montjoie (5)** a few paces from the tourist office.

LES CONTAMINES-MONTJOIE (1167m, 5–5½hrs) Office de tourisme (Tel 04 50 47 01 58; info@lescontamines.com; www.lescontamines.com) hotels, pensions, dortoirs, gîte, CAF refuge, camping; restaurants, shops (last supplies until Courmayeur), bank, ATM, PTT, bus link with St-Gervais-les-Bains. Lower-priced accommodation: Refuge de la CAF, 28 dortoir places, open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 00 88); Chalet Bonaventure, 8 dortoir places, open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 23 53; camille.bonaventure@wanadoo.fr). Hotel Christiana, beds (Tel 04 50 47 02 72). The Gîte Du Pontet is located at Camping Le Pontet (Tel 04 50 47 04 04; campingdupontet@wanadoo.fr), 2km south of the village: 32 dortoir places, open Jan to late Sept. See [Stage 2](#) for access. For complete hotel details contact the tourist office, which also produces an annual accommodation list for the whole TMB.



The village of Les Contamines

ALTERNATIVE STAGE 1*Les Houches – Refuge de Miage – Les Contamines*

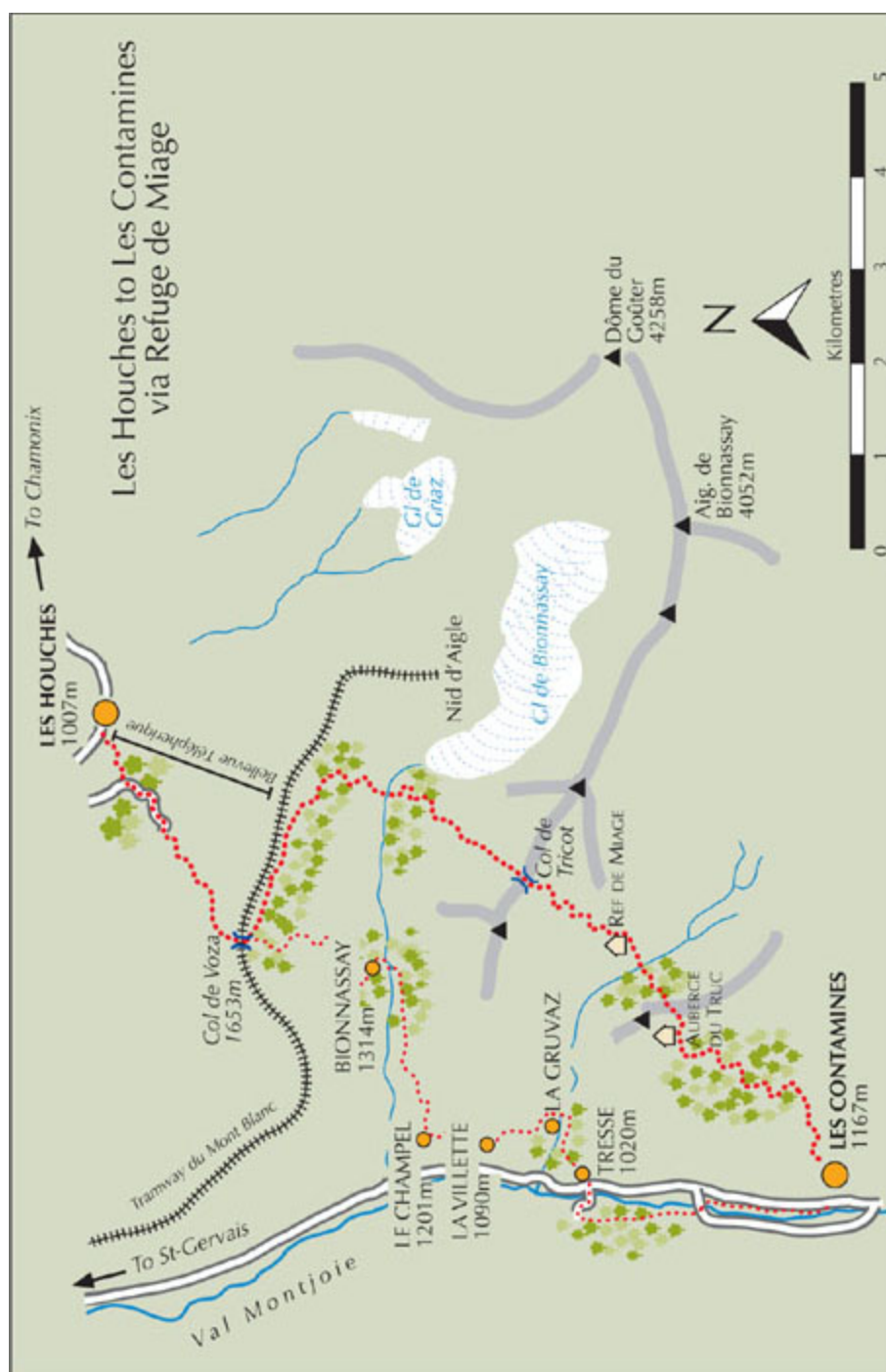
Start point	Les Houches (1007m)
Distance	18km
Height gain	1478m
Height loss	1318m
Time	7½hrs
High point	Col de Tricot (2120m)
Transport options	Cableway (Les Houches – Bellevue); Cableway (Les Houches/Les Chavants – Prarion); Train (St-Gervais – Col de Voza–Bellevue)
Accommodation	Les Houches – hotels, dortoirs, gîte, camping; Col de Voza (2¼–2½hrs) – hotel; Chalets de Miage (5–5½hrs) – refuge; Truc (6hrs) – auberge; Les Contamines – hotels, dortoirs, gîte, CAF refuge, camping
Alternative route	Col de Voza – Les Contamines via Bionnassay (see Stage 1)

The bare statistics of height gain and loss, and the amount of time calculated to walk this stage, underline the fact that it's a demanding route for a first day. But it's also a magnificent section, rich in high mountain views and a worthy introduction to the Tour of Mont Blanc. As far as Col de Voza, the route is the same as that for the main TMB, but thereafter the two options are very different. This is a true high route, for the trail ventures close to the world of glacier, moraine and rock, crosses a 2000m pass (Col de Tricot) and avoids permanent habitation until Les Contamines is reached.

One need not go all the way to Les Contamines on this stage and there's much to be said for choosing either Refuge de Miage or Auberge du Truc in which to spend the night, both giving a sense of remote tranquility under the Dômes de Miage.

A note of warning before setting out: check the weather forecast in Les Houches, and if a storm is predicted, opt for the main TMB route via Bionnassay, for there's no real shelter between Col de Voza and the Chalets de Miage, and crossing Col de Tricot in stormy conditions is inadvisable. But if the weather looks good, go for it! It's a great walk.





For the route from Les Houches **(1)** to **Col de Voza (1653m, [refreshments](#))**, follow directions given under Stage 1 above. Col de Voza is reached in 2¼–2½hrs.

Cross the railway and turn left immediately past the bar-restaurant where a track rises alongside the line of the Tramway du Mont Blanc **(2)**, and about 20mins later come to the refurbished Hotel Bellevue (1786m, [accommodation](#), [refreshments](#)). The building is well named, for the view all along this ridge is very fine indeed. To the left the Chamonix valley stretches towards Col de Balme, Le Brévent and the Aiguilles Rouges forming the left-hand wall of the valley, the Chamonix Aiguilles on the right, while directly ahead the Dôme du Goûter stands a little left of the rounded snow hump of Mont Blanc itself. Make the most of this view, for it will soon be lost, and you'll not see the Chamonix valley again until you cross the Col de Balme in about eight days' time.

Just beyond the building veer slightly right across a meadow where a path takes you onto a steep, partly wooded hillside that sweeps down into the Bionnassay valley. Making an undulating

traverse of the slope, go through a gate and join a second path coming from Bionnassay. Keep ahead, through another gate and along an easy contour to a T-junction of paths (25mins from Bellevue), where you turn right across an open meadow with splendid views up to the cascading Glacier de Bionnassay **(3)**.

The way now goes onto the wooded lateral moraine bulldozed by the glacier, and descends among trees to a Himalayan-style suspension bridge (1650m) that spans the roaring glacial torrent – a wash of coffee-coloured water spewing from the rubble-strewn snout of the glacier. This is just the latest in a whole series of bridges across the Bionnassay torrent, the previous incarnations having been destroyed by avalanche or swept away by a spring flood.

Across the bridge the way twists uphill through dense vegetation to another path junction. The right-hand option descends to Bionnassay and Le Champel, but we climb on among trees, now making for Col de Tricot which lies some 400m higher up the hillside. It's a steep climb, but out of the trees the path snakes up grass slopes of the Combe de Tricot dotted with alpenroses, with views of the Aiguilles du Goûter and Bionnassay guarding the upper glacier, while across the valley the line of the Tramway du Mont Blanc is clearly visible.

Col de Tricot (2120m) is reached in about 4-4½hrs from Les Houches. This is a broad, grassy saddle on a long ridge spur stretching down from the Aiguille de Bionnassay, forming a partition between the valleys of Bionnassay to the north and Miage to the south. On the saddle there's a low stone wall and the remains of a one-time building, and from it you look steeply down to the Chalets de Miage huddled almost 600m below on the edge of the Miage pastures.

Numerous zigzags take you down on the south side of the ridge. The gradient is very steep in places and caution is advised, for it's on descents like this, tackled in the early stages of a long trek, that knees can be damaged – especially if you're carrying a reasonably heavy rucksack, as you would if backpacking. Trekking poles, suitably lengthened for such a descent, will help take some of the pressure off.

In the midst of the cluster of buildings that go under the name of the Chalets de Miage you'll find the

REFUGE DE MIAGE (1550m, 5-5½hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 37 dortoir places, 2 rooms; open June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 93 22 91).

The refuge has a very fine outlook to the head of the little hanging valley which is topped by the snow-crested Dômes de Miage. The situation is idyllic, and a night spent here is worth considering. Camping may be permitted – enquire at the refuge. From here the TMB path crosses a stream and brings you onto a track where, across a bridge, a signpost directs you left to Le Truc and Les Contamines. This path tacks easily up the walling hillside to the Mont Truc ridge crest, a climb of around 160m, taking about 40mins to reach the

AUBERGE DU TRUC (1720m, 6hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 28 dortoir places; open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 93 12 48).



The Dômes de Miage close the head of the secluded Miage valley

The auberge stands in an open meadow with the Dômes de Miage and their glaciers appearing even closer than they did from the Miage meadows. In the opposite direction the view extends down the Val Montjoie **(4)** to the lower valley of the Arve. [The view from Mont Truc](#) ('truc' means rounded summit) at the end of the ridge spur is said to be excellent.

Walk down the track for about 15mins, and on rounding the first sharp right-hand bend take a path on the left signed to Contamines. This descends a forested hillside and rejoins the track at 1512m. Turn left and wander down the track, or unsurfaced road, for the rest of the descent to a car park at **La Frasse (1263m, 7hrs)**, where there's a public toilet and a water supply on the left. Continue down towards Les Contamines, following waymarks past old farm buildings on a stony path that shortcuts the road, then down among houses of the upper part of the village where a series of paths (the Chemin du P'tou) lead all the way to the church in **Les Contamines-Montjoie (5)** a short walk from the tourist office – turn right along the main road for this.

LES CONTAMINES-MONTJOIE (1167m, 7½hrs) Office de tourisme (Tel 04 50 47 01 58; info@lescontamines.com); hotels, pensions, dortoirs, gîte, CAF refuge, camping; restaurants, shops (last supplies until Courmayeur), bank, ATM, PTT, bus link with St-Gervais-les-Bains. Lower-priced accommodation: Refuge du CAF, 28 dortoir places, open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 00 88); Chalet Bonaventure, 8 dortoir places, open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 23 53; camille.bonaventure@wanadoo.fr). Hotel Christiana, beds, (Tel 04 50 47 02 72, hotel-christiania@wanadoo.fr; www.lechristiania-hotel.com). The Gîte Du Pontet is located at Camping Le Pontet (Tel 04 50 47 04 04; campingdupontet@wanadoo.fr), 2km south of the village: 32 dortoir places, open June to late Sept. See [Stage 2](#) for access details. For complete hotel details contact the tourist office, which also produces an annual accommodation list for the whole TMB.

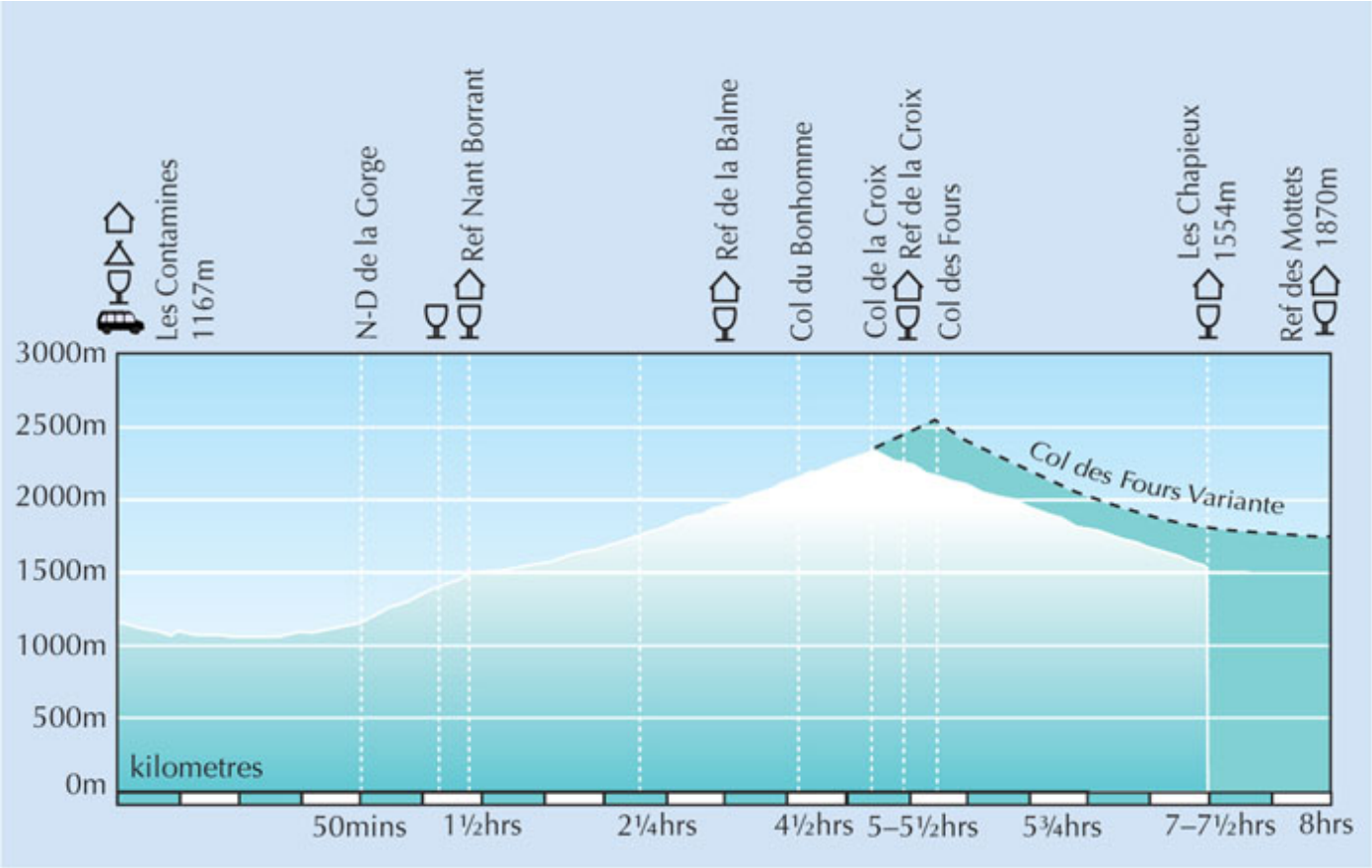
STAGE 2

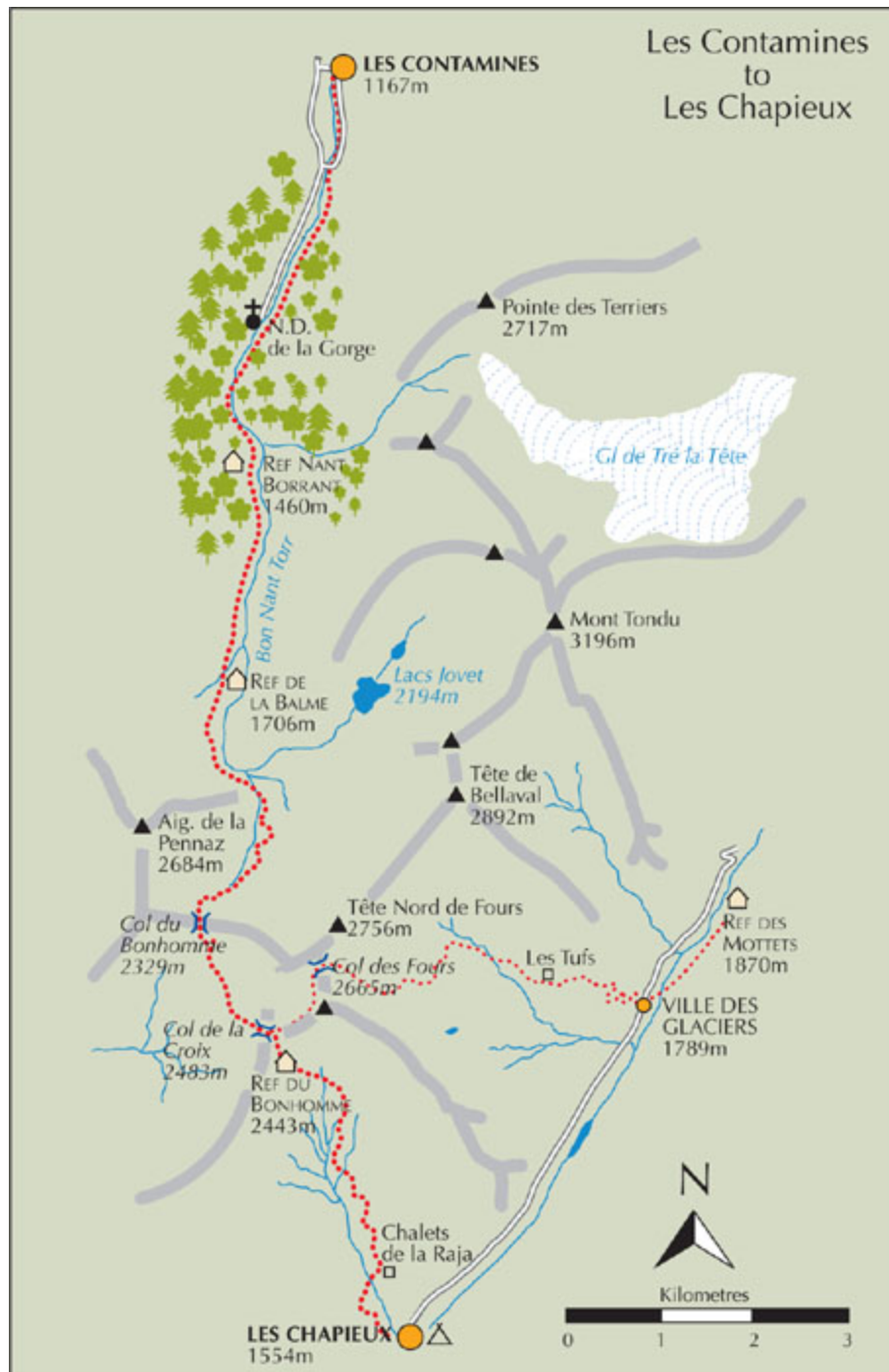
Les Contamines – Col de la Croix du Bonhomme – Les Chapieux

Start point	Les Contamines (1167m)
Distance	18km or 20km via Col des Fours to Refuge des Mottets
Height gain	1316m (or 1579m)
Height loss	929m (or 876m)
Time	7–7½hrs or 7½–8hrs via Col des Fours <i>variante</i>
High point	Col de la Croix du Bonhomme 2483m or Col des Fours 2665m
Transport option	Bus (Les Contamines – Notre-Dame de la Gorge)
Accommodation	Pontet (40mins) – gîte d'étape, camping; Nant-Barrant (1½hrs) – chalet/gîte; La Balme (2½hrs) – chalet/gîte; Col de la Croix (5–5½hrs) – CAF refuge; Les Chapieux – auberge /refuge, camping; Les Mottets (7½–8hrs) – refuge (Col des Fours option)
Alternative route	Col de la Croix du Bonhomme – Col des Fours – Refuge des Mottets (see below)

On this stage the TMB goes right to the head of Val Montjoie and crosses over into the Vallée des Glaciers by way of Col du Bonhomme and Col de la Croix du Bonhomme. Although more challenging than Stage 1 (via Bionnassay), it does not equal the high-route alternative first stage in physical demands, but it's a reasonably tough crossing nonetheless. Early in the season snow will no doubt remain in patches between the two cols, in which case special care will need to be taken. Just below the highest of these the Refuge de la Croix du Bonhomme commands a splendid position and makes a good alternative overnight option, although Les Chapieux has a relaxing atmosphere on a bend in the Vallée des Glaciers, but without any noteworthy views.

On arrival at Col de la Croix du Bonhomme, a TMB *variante* ignores the descent to Les Chapieux and rises to the barren Col des Fours before descending to the valley at Ville des Glaciers, an hour or so upvalley beyond Les Chapieux. Walkers taking this option will probably choose to continue to Refuge des Mottets for accommodation. Under good snow-free conditions the Col des Fours route makes a worthy alternative to the standard crossing, but early in the season, or in inclement weather or poor visibility, the main route to Les Chapieux should be taken. Both options are described.





South of Les Contamines cross the river on a footbridge by the first road bridge after leaving the main village, then follow the river upstream for about 10mins. For accommodation at the comfortable Chalet-Hotel La Chemenaz (Tel 04 50 47 02 44), turn right; the hotel is about 2mins' walk away. Cross to the left side and resume on a tree-lined path which soon swings left to bring you parallel with the road. When the road makes a sharp right-hand turn to cross the river, walk ahead on a good broad and level path, soon passing a water supply. A little later note a small lake on the right, with a bar/restaurant on its shore. Camping Le Pontet and its gîte (see details at the end of the previous stage) are not far from here. About 45mins from Les Contamines reach a junction of paths near the pilgrimage chapel of **Notre-Dame de la Gorge (6) (1210m)**. Should you need refreshment, there's a café-restaurant next to the chapel.



This tree-fringed lake lies beside the route between Les Contamines and Notre-Dame de la Gorge

The TMB path now rises directly ahead up the steep left-hand side of a wooded ravine on Roman-laid slabs, passing a rock arch (Pont Naturel) to the right, then easing to cross the hump-backed Pont de la Téma about 10mins before coming to the Relais le Sollié ([refreshments](#)) and, shortly after, an attractive chalet-style building in a neat garden on the right:

REFUGE NANT BORRANT (1460m, 1½hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 35 dortoir places; open early June to late Sept (Tel 04 50 47 03 57; refugenantborrant@free.fr).

At this point you enter the Réserve Naturelle des Contamines-Montjoie **(7)**. Here you cross a stream, rise a little further and, 10mins from Nant Borrant the way forks. A sign here indicates that overnight camping is permitted 100m down to the left; a very pleasant site just above the river. The TMB continues along the right branch, easing into a stretch of open meadowland with the shapely Aiguilles de la Pennaz ahead. Near the far end of this level stretch there's a water supply on the left of the track. About 20mins beyond this, having climbed again, a sign indicates another [emplacement de bivouac](#) (overnight campsite) 100m to the right. By the main track note another water supply and a small public toilet block, just above which you will come to the

REFUGE DE LA BALME (1706m, 2¼hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 36 dortoir places, 14 beds; open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 47 03 54).



In the upper Val Montjoie the Aiguille de la Pennaz dominates

The jeep track loops up the hillside, but about 2mins beyond La Balme a footpath breaks away on the left and ascends steeply over rough ground with stony zigzags for 30mins or so until reaching a bluff with an electricity pylon. About 5mins beyond the pylon the way forks. Both routes merge a little higher across a basin running with streams – the right-hand path, which crosses a stream or two, can be rather marshy at times, but it also leads through a veritable flower garden in the early summer. This basin is known as the Plan Jovet, and off to the left a cascade can be seen pouring from a hanging valley that contains the two Lacs Jovet – a picturesque spot. Ignoring this, the TMB climbs through a narrow rocky section to the Plan des Dames, marked by a huge pile of stones said to be on the spot where an English woman perished in a storm. Tossing a stone onto the pile is something of a ritual – as it is in mountain country throughout the world.



The route between Col du Bonhomme and the higher Col de la Croix du Bonhomme

Col du Bonhomme is clearly visible almost 300m above, and large patches of snow often lie across the slopes leading to it. Across the Plan des Dames the path takes the right-hand side of the valley, and, as height is gained, so the way breaks into several strands rising across shaly slopes to converge on the saddle of **Col du Bonhomme (2329m, 4½hrs)**, where there's a small wooden shelter. In good conditions this is a charming place; a broad saddle between the Rocher du Bonhomme and Bancs de la Pennaz, with long views down through the Val Montjoie to the north, and Vallon de la Gittaz in the Beaufortain district to the southwest. A path drops into this latter valley, brightened by the Lac de la Gittaz and much more extensive Lac de Roselend, while our path still has more height to gain.

Bear left along the saddle and begin rising once more into a wilder, more stony region of scree and rocks and, quite possibly, a few late-lying snow patches. In misty conditions this can seem an eerie place, but on a good day the route is one to enjoy, with anticipation of the next pass luring you on as views grow in extent. Minor streams drain across the path, and about 45mins from Col du Bonhomme you come to the large cairn which marks the summit of **Col de la Croix du Bonhomme (2483m, 5–5¼hrs)**. Before you the hillside folds down to the hinted Vallée des Glaciers, while mountains, ridges and other valleys of Beaufortain provide a very different landscape to that which you've left behind. To the south Mont Pourri dominates.

Refuge de la Croix du Bonhomme lies just 50m and 5mins below on the south side of the ridge, but before descending to it, a decision must be made as to the continuing route, options being:

- via Col des Fours to Refuge des Mottets (see box), or
- the standard TMB route to Les Chapieux via Refuge de la Croix (see main route description below).

The first option is a little longer than the standard route, but as it reduces Stage 3 by about 1½hrs, and avoids a stretch of road-walking, it might be preferred. However, Col des Fours should not be attempted if much snow is lying, nor if there's any threat of bad weather or poor visibility. The second option is a fine route in any case, but one also has the possibility of spending the night at Refuge de la Croix du Bonhomme, and making a decision as to the continuing route next day.

TMB VARIANTE: COL DES FOURS – REFUGE DES MOTTETS

Bear left at Col de la Croix and go up the ridge crest to an electricity pylon. Beyond this the way cuts along the left (west) flank of Tête Sud des Fours to gain the bare saddle of **Col des Fours (2665m, 5¾hrs)**, about 35mins from Col de la Croix. Along with the Fenêtre d'Arpette (Alt. Stage 8), this is the highest point reached on the TMB, and from it Mont Blanc can be seen to the northeast beyond the Aiguille des Glaciers, a shining dome of snow and ice. Should you have sufficient time and energy, it's worth continuing as far as the 2756m summit of Tête Nord des Fours (8), where the 360° panorama is magnificent. (Allow 40mins for the round trip from Col des Fours.)

Cross the col and descend southeastwards on steep slopes of shale and, possibly, snow patches towards the basin of Plan des Fours. After losing about 250m of height, veer left when the path forks, cross a stream that drops through a gully, and then descend steeply alongside, then across, the Tufts stream and over pastures to the deserted alp buildings of **Les Tufts (1993m), about 1–1¼hrs** from Col des Fours. Here you join a farm road and wander down it to more farm buildings that go by the grand name of **La Ville des Glaciers (1789m, 7½hrs)**. (Note the public toilets in the small car park.) Cross the road and go down to the Torrent des Glaciers on a track which crosses the river and rises gently to the atmospheric converted dairy farm of **Refuge des Mottets (1870m, 8hrs, accommodation, refreshments; 90 places; open mid-June to mid-Sept; (04 79 07 01 70; refuge@lesmottets.com).**

Main route to Les Chapieux

From Col de la Croix du Bonhomme it is only a 5min walk down to the refuge. Unless snow has obscured it the path, which descends southward, is easy to follow and soon brings you to

REFUGE DE LA CROIX DU BONHOMME (9) (2443m, 5–5¼hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 113 dortoir places; manned mid-June to mid-Sept; (Tel 04 79 07 05 28; refuge-bonhomme@free.fr).

A rather curious-looking building, it enjoys a commanding position, and the view from it, whilst not containing any dramatic mountains, is charming – especially in the soft light of evening.

The path veers left at the refuge to negotiate a series of grassy bluffs and streams before descending fairly steeply to the south on the way to the Chalets de Plan Varraro (alp buildings) at 2006m. Passing these to your left the path drops steeply once more to another group of buildings, the **Chalets de la Raja (1789m, 6½hrs)**, where you bear right, cross a bridge and come onto a stony jeep track. Follow this round the hillside to the left until coming to a junction where you take the lower option (sign to Refuge La Nova). Keep alert for a footpath that drops through pastures on the left, and brings you to the hamlet of **Les Chapieux** on a bend in the Vallée des Glaciers **(10)**, directly opposite the Auberge de la Nova.

LES CHAPIEUX (1554m, 7–7½hrs) accommodation, refreshments in Auberge de la Nova, 35 dortoir places, 35 beds; open May to end Oct; (Tel 04 79 89 07 15; info@refugelanova.com); camping permitted in meadows below the hamlet – public toilet block next to a seasonal tourist office; small grocery.

NO LONGER A 'WRETCHED LITTLE HAMLET'

When AW Moore and his guide, Christian Almer, came to Les Chapieux in July 1864 on their way from Bourg St Maurice to the Pavillon Bellevue above Col de Voza (an epic walk of 10½hrs), Moore was unimpressed, calling it a 'wretched little hamlet'. It was 8.40 in the morning, and the two men, in need of refreshment, went into the 'larger of the two little inns [which] has a bad reputation, and, according to our experience, deservedly so. I ordered an omelette and a bottle of red wine,' said Moore, 'and in lieu of the latter was furnished with a chopine of what was perfect vinegar, of the sourest and most undrinkable character, which not even a copious mixture of water could make palatable, much less wholesome. The charge was extortionate, and at 9.15 we departed,

congratulating ourselves that we were not compelled to make a long halt in such a den of thieves, the situation of which is most dreary and devoid of interest.' (*The Alps* in 1864)

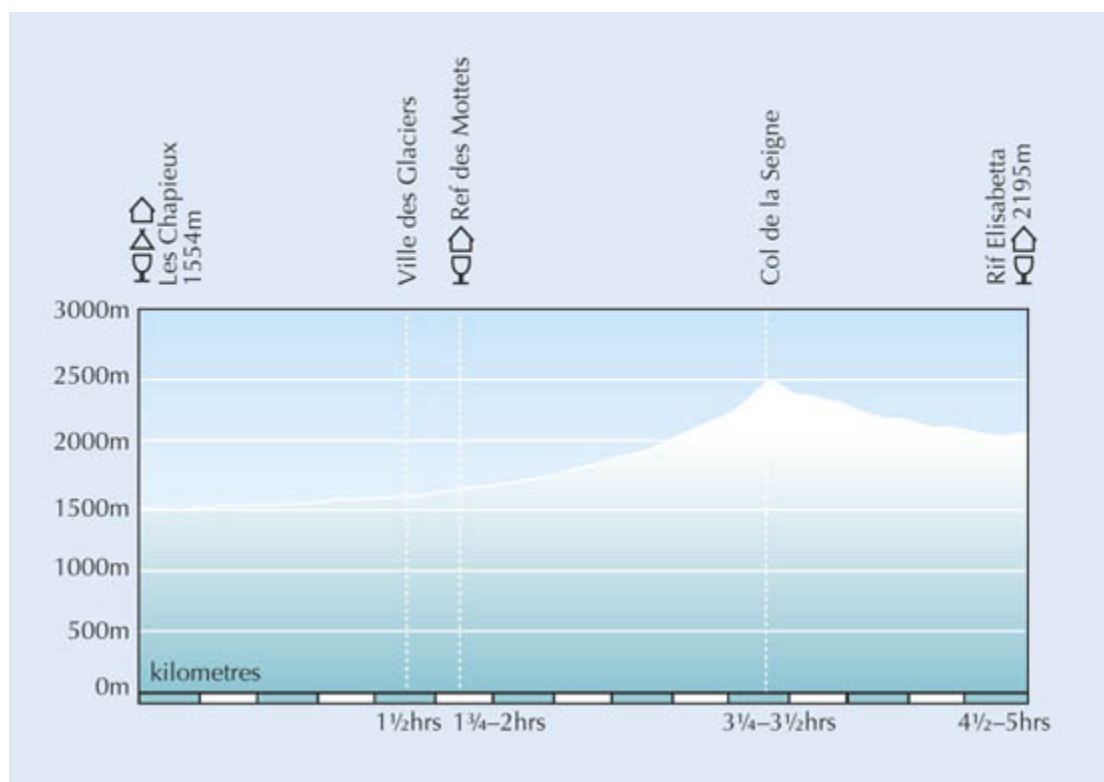
Happily, the experience of TMB walkers in Les Chapieux today is unlikely to mirror that of the unfortunate AW Moore.

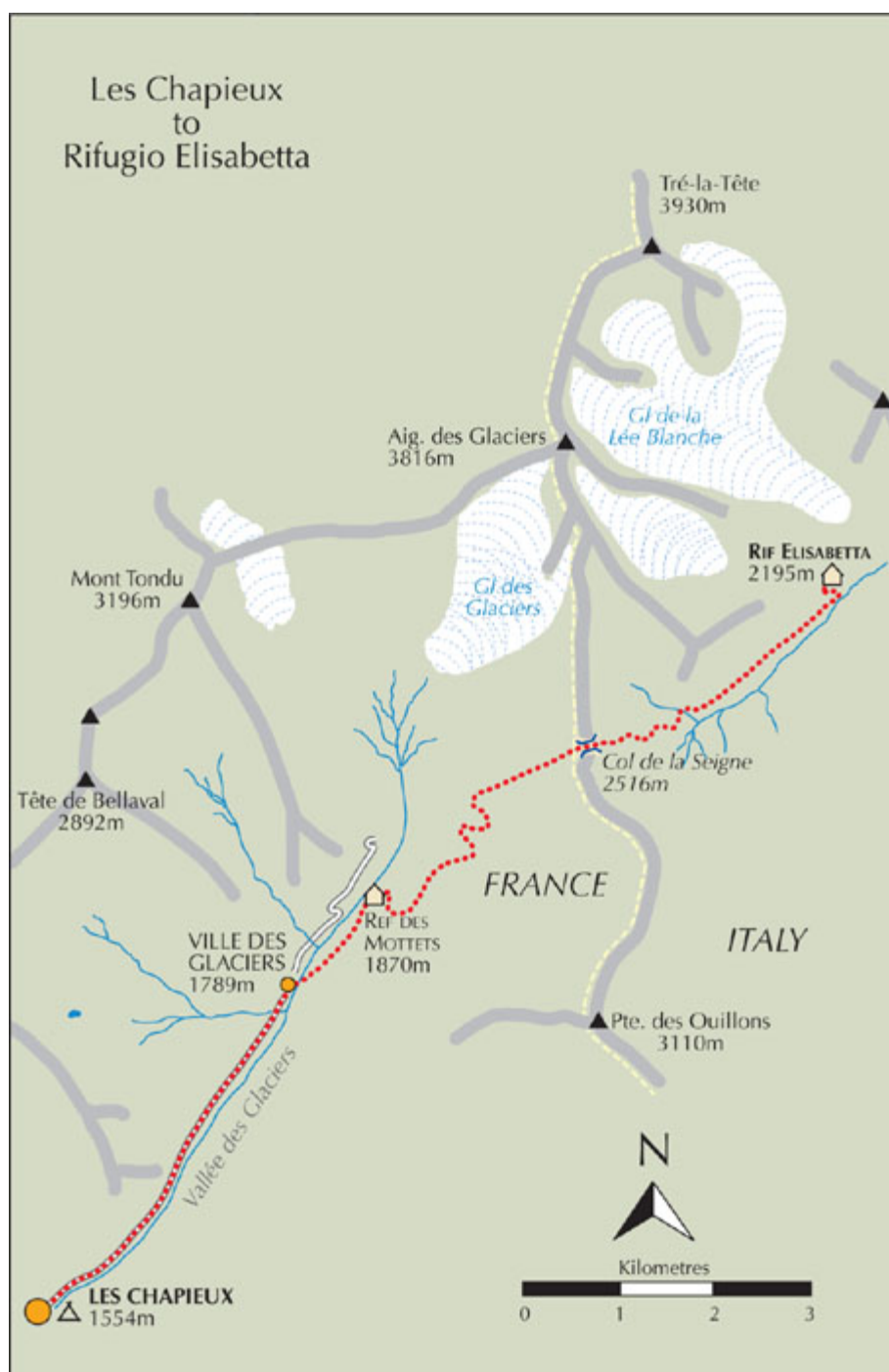
STAGE 3*Les Chapieux – Col de la Seigne – Rifugio Elisabetta*

Start point	Les Chapieux (1554m)
Distance	15km
Height gain	1004m
Height loss	258m
Time	4½–5hrs
High point	Col de la Seigne (2516m)
Accommodation	Les Mottets (2hrs) – privately-owned refuge; Rifugio Elisabetta – CAI refuge

On this stage the TMB crosses out of France and enters Italy at the Col de la Seigne, one of the easiest crossings of the circuit, but one which also happens to be among the most scenic. Given reasonable visibility, the view of Mont Blanc and the Aiguille Noire from Col de la Seigne is stunning, and is seen at its best early in the morning.

This relatively short stage will enable you to relax a little after what will have been two fairly demanding days, and there's a good chance you'll arrive at Rifugio Elisabetta with plenty of time in hand. As there's no alternative accommodation for several more hours, it would be sensible to reserve a place by telephone before setting out. The code for Italy is 0039. The number for the rifugio is given at the end of the route description.





Walk out of Les Chapieux heading northeast along the road, shortly joining company with the river and entering a defile which is, in effect, the demarcation between the lower and upper valleys. Once through this the steep-sided valley begins to open a little to show the ice pinnacle of the Aiguille des Glaciers beckoning ahead, and as you make progress towards it, so the Col de la Seigne also becomes evident to the right of the Aiguille. It will take about 1½hrs to reach the Ville des Glaciers, and it's road-walking all the way – tarmac as far as the lone building of **Seloge (1809m, 1hr 10mins)**, then unsurfaced. There's usually little traffic, the road rises above the river and its strip of pasture, and the valley is pleasant in an undemonstrative way, although it has often been described, perhaps a little unfairly, as being somewhat wild and desolate. Apart from the construction of the road and a few buildings it has not really been tamed – but wild and desolate? Not in a true sense, and when lit by a bright sun it can seem positively welcoming.



The small hamlet of Les Chapieux nestles on a bend in the Vallée des Glaciers

As you come to the few farm buildings of **La Ville des Glaciers (1789m, 1½hrs)** the upper basin of the valley spreads out to reveal the rocky eminence of Mont Tondu above to the left. It is here that the Col des Fours *variante* joins the main route. It would be sensible to top up water bottles here, for apart from the refuge 30mins ahead, there will be no further guaranteed supply until you reach Rifugio Elisabetta.

Turn right and descend to the bridge which spans the Torrent des Glaciers, and wander along the jeep track heading upvalley to the ruins of a one-time hotel. About 30mins beyond the bridge come to the former dairy farm that has been converted to the

REFUGE DES MOTTETS (1870m, 2hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 90 dortoir places; open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 79 07 01 70; refuge@lesmottets.com).

This is an atmospheric place for a night's lodging, with a dining room decorated with an assortment of old cheese-making implements, and the former cowshed turned into a dormitory. As it is the only place for refreshments between Les Chapieux and Rifugio Elisabetta, it's worth stopping to tank up before heading for the pass.

From here the route to the col is neither long nor particularly arduous, although it has a few short, steep sections. Initially a broad, well-graded path, it later breaks into a skein of often muddy trails. Ascending high pastures, it dips into a stream-cut ravine and eases up the final broad slope that leads to the **Col de la Seigne (11) (2516m, 3¼–3½hrs)** and the revelation of a new world.

Arrival at the col is an eye-opener. Standing on the borders of France and Italy views in all directions are magnificent. Directly ahead the hillside falls away into a long, deep trench that forms a moat to the southern bastions of the Mont Blanc range. Immediately below the col the Vallon de la Lée Blanche, guarded by the Pyramides Calcaires, spills into the Vel Veni, which in itself leads to the (Italian) Val Ferret, at whose head the Grand Col Ferret will be crossed in another three days' time. Beyond that rise Mont Vêlan and the Grand Combin. Along the right-hand wall of this 'moat' a rumpled green hillside carries the route of the TMB, while the left-hand wall boasts a succession of astonishingly rugged peaks and spiky ridges interrupted by cascades of ice and grey moraines. Dominant in all this is the graceful iced dome of Mont Blanc itself, with the spectacular Aiguille Noire de Peuterey running a close second. The scene is exquisite and dominated by verticals.



An early morning cloud-sea below Col de la Seigne fills the Val Veni

Given calm settled weather, Col de la Seigne is not an easy place to leave. In snow-free conditions the path down into the Vallon de la Lée Blanche is easy to follow, but if visibility is poor, or snow patches remain on the east side, care should be taken on the initial descent. There are, in fact, several braidings at first, but these come together lower down as a good path. About 10mins from the col the waymarked path goes alongside a renovated former customs house, La Casermetta (2365m). This is now used as a museum and mountain information centre, and is worth a short visit. The way continues down into the pastures of Lée (or Lex) Blanche, the uppermost reaches of the Val Veni. Other writers have dismissed this valley as either dreary, wild, a desolate combe, or as having a melancholy character. I find it excitingly full of promise. Delineated by streams, the pastures are grazed by cattle in summer, and as you wander across the level grasslands, cowbells ringing in your ears, so your attention is drawn time and again to the great rocky spear of the Aiguille Noir ahead.



Rifugio Elisabetta stands on a spur overlooking the Vallon de la Lée Blanche

The levels of Lée Blanche end at the cluster of old buildings known as the Alpe inférieur de la Lex Blanche (2258m). Turn sharp left here and ascend a narrow path for about 10mins to reach the

RIFUGIO ELISABETTA (2195m, 4½–5hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 53 dortoir places, 20 beds; manned mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 01 65 84 40 80; info@rifugioelisabetta.com). Owned and staffed by the Milan section of the CAI the rifugio, officially named Elisabetta Soldini, overlooks the lower Vallon de la Lée Blanche from a spur extending from one of the Pyramides Calcaires, and is backed by the Glacier d'Estellette and Glacier de la Lée Blanche. Despite its stated capacity, the number of visitors may well exceed this in the high season. Sunset views can be magical.

STAGE 4

Rifugio Elisabetta – Courmayeur

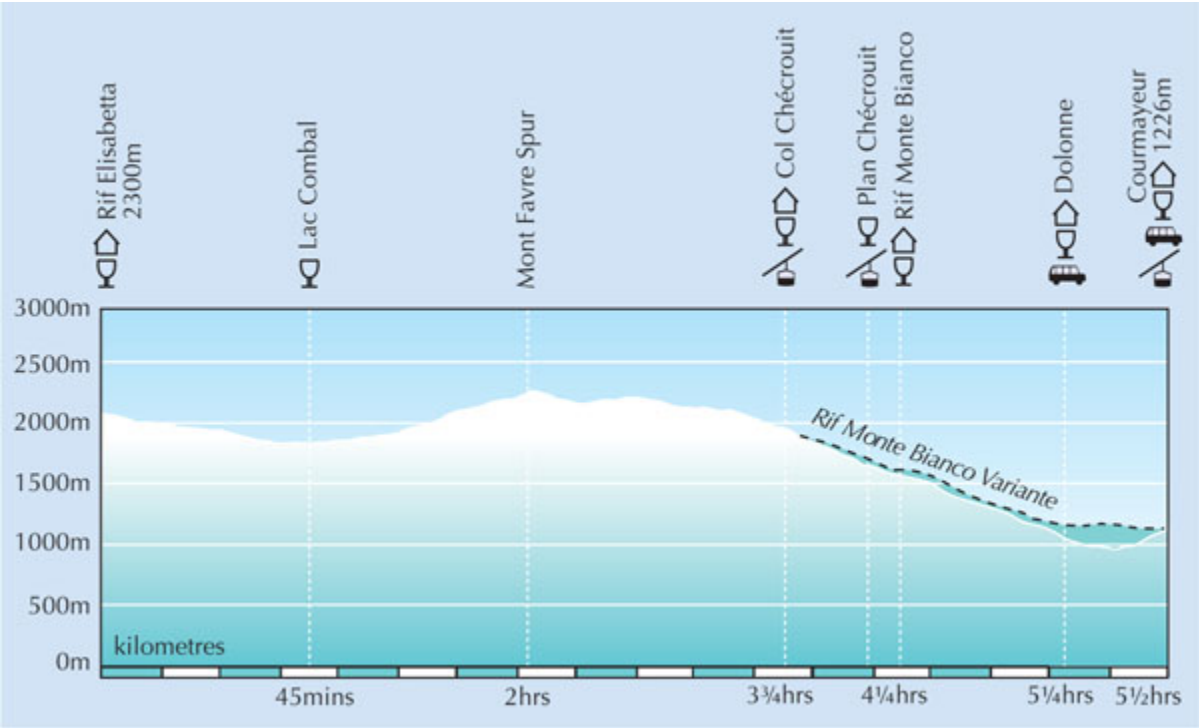
Start point	Rifugio Elisabetta (2195m)
Distance	18km or 20km via Rifugio Monte Bianco
Height gain	460m
Height loss	1560m
Time	5–5½hrs
High point	Mont Favre spur (2430m)
Transport options	Bus (La Visaille – Courmayeur); Cablecar (Plan Chécrouit – Courmayeur)
Accommodation	Col Chécrouit (3¾hrs) – privately-owned gîte-refuge; Val Veni (2–2½hrs) – camping, gîte, hotel (Val Veni option); Val Veni (4¼hrs) – CAI refuge (Rifugio Monte Bianco option); Dolonne (5hrs) – hotel; Courmayeur – hotels, pensions
Alternative routes	via Val Veni all the way to Courmayeur – a bad-weather ‘escape’ route (see below).; Col Chécrouit – Rif. Monte Bianco – Courmayeur (see below)

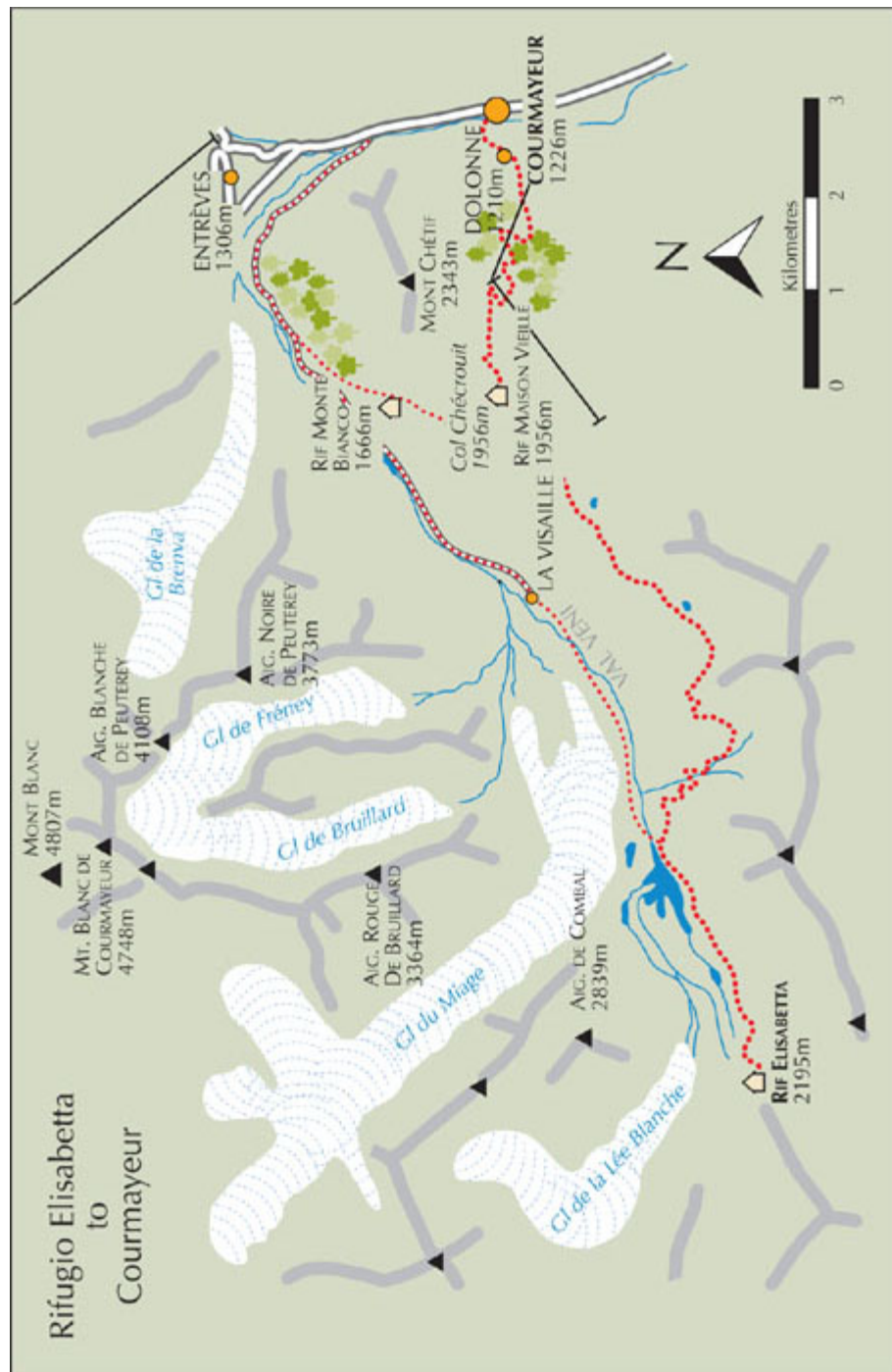
Although there are no passes to cross on this stage, and the amount of height gain is modest, the undulating nature of the high route along the south flank of the Val Veni can make this seem a fairly demanding day.

This is a wonderfully varied walk among scenery of the highest order. It begins by dropping into the lower Vallon de la Lée Blanche, where a tracery of streams combine to create the so-called Lac Combal, backed by the monstrous wall of moraine thrown up by the Glacier de Miage that spills into the valley between gateways of rock. On gaining the foot of this moraine wall, the TMB then swings to the right and climbs steeply up the right-hand hillside, passes two groups of derelict alp buildings and continues until reaching a high point on a spur coming from Mont Favre. From here to Col Chécrouit the route follows a balcony path of immense appeal – every step further unravels a sumptuous view of ‘the disordered and magnificent cluster of the great peaks, and of Mont Blanc itself’, as Roger Frison-Roche once described it. Two or three small pools lie along this hillside to create a mirror image of the aiguilles and snowpeaks opposite.

At Col Chécrouit the main route as described descends to Courmayeur via the attractive village of Dolonne, while an alternative option (also described) invites walkers down into Val Veni to skirt the northern base of Mont Chétif, and then to approach Courmayeur from the north.

Finally, should the weather be very bad, you are advised to ignore the ‘high route’ as described beyond Lac Combal, and remain in the bed of Val Veni throughout – a walk of about 3½–4hrs from Rifugio Elisabetta; outline details given below.





Out of the refuge descend to the buildings of Alpe inférieure, where an unmetalled road, built by the Italian army, comes up from Lac Combal. Footpath shortcuts enable you to avoid most of the road-walking until you reach the valley floor, but thereafter you can swing easily along, either on the road itself or its grassy verge, almost as far as a stone bridge at 1950m at the northern end of the milky-blue Lac Combal below the wall of lateral moraine. This is reached in about 45mins. Despite the road (which can be horribly dusty following a spell of dry weather), the landscape is of such value that your attention is likely to be anywhere but on the road itself.



Lac Combal and the Aiguille Noire de Peuterey

The TMB turns off shortly before the bridge. However, should you need refreshment there's a small buvette on the other side of the river off to the left. The bridge is also crossed if you decide to catch a bus, or plan to walk all the way to Courmayeur through the Val Veni **(12)** – see section below.

TMB Bad-Weather Option: Val Veni To Courmayeur

From the bridge at the northern end of Lac Combal, walk down the road for about 30mins, then take a footpath on the right descending briefly through larchwoods to rejoin the road a little lower. About 10mins later enter the hamlet of **La Visaille** from where there's a bus service to Courmayeur. A few paces beyond Chalet del Miage ([refreshments](#)) a signed footpath descends on the left, leading downvalley in another 30mins or so to **Camping La Sorgente** and its gîte (8 dortoir places, 22 beds, open June to mid-Sept Tel 01 65 86 90 89; info@campingsorgente.net). Continuing down the road, when it makes a left-hand hairpin just out of La Visaille, note a path/track which goes straight ahead for another 45mins to reach **Rifugio Monte Bianco** (1666m, 14 dortoir places, 50 beds; open mid-June to mid-Sept Tel 01 65 86 90 97). The road snakes downhill with footpath shortcuts, and comes to **Camping Aiguille Noire** (with on-site refreshments and shop; Tel 01 65 869 014; www.aiguillenoire.com), before passing a side road on the left going to **Pertud** (Peuterey; 1502m), Camping Monte Bianco La Sorgente, the gîte mentioned above, and two hotels. About 20mins later you pass below the pilgrimage chapel of Notre Dame de la Guérison, and in another hour reach **Courmayeur** (see main route for details).

Main route to Courmayeur

For the TMB high route take the path which you will see on the right about 50m before the bridge. It angles up the vegetated hillside and in a little under 20mins brings you to the ruins of Alpe inférieure de l'Arp Vieille, then more directly up the slope before crossing a stream, and climbing again to Alpe supérieure de l'Arp Vieille (2303m, 1¾hrs) – another abandoned building with an outlook across the valley directly onto the Miage glacier. The whole southern face of the Mont Blanc range is being revealed now, and the higher you climb the more of it you see and the more one gains a true impression of the vast scale of these mountains. In the Himalaya one

would need to walk for many a long day to capture such a vision as you will see from this high path.

Above Alpe supérieure the way rises further to pass above a small pool, then angles leftward up a spur projecting from Mont Favre. Rounding this about 30mins or so above Alpe supérieure, you attain the highest point on the walk at 2430m. From here the full sweeping majesty of crag, spire, snow-dome, rockface and nosing glacier that makes up the north wall of the Vals Veni and Ferret is laid before you. Yet this is just one vantage point among many to be visited on the walk to Courmayeur.



Morning light on the Aiguille Noire, seen across the Val Veni from Col Chécrouit

Moving on, the path slopes down into a combe, crosses a stream on stepping stones where the water has cut a groove, then rises over a grass bluff to pass another small pool off to the right (a photographer's delight). Mostly over grass slopes, but sometimes among trees, the path meanders on, passes below Lac Chécrouit, and continues towards Col Chécrouit, which is found at the foot of a minor wooded slope.

Col Chécrouit (1956m, 3¾hrs, [accommodation](#), [refreshments](#)) is a wonderful location with a view across the valley into the armchair-like hollow known as the Fauteuil des Allemands on the face of the Aiguille Noire de Peuterey, and south through the narrows of Val d'Aosta to outliers of the Gran Paradiso range. Overnight accommodation may be had in the privately-owned

RIFUGIO MAISON VIEILLE 50 [dortoir places](#); open from mid-June to end Sept (Tel 337 23 09 79; info@maisonvieille.com; www.maisonvieille.com).

Nearby the slopes have been laced with cableways, and bulldozed pistes scar the hillsides as a direct contrast to the untamed landscapes walked thus far.

There are two ways to proceed from here:

- descend leftwards to Rifugio Monte Bianco and Notre Dame de la Guérison in the Val Veni, then round the base of Mont Chétif to Courmayeur (see 'TMB *variante*' box below), or
- go ahead and right to Plan Chécrouit on tracks and footpaths, then down to Dolonne and Courmayeur (described in the next section).

The first takes a little longer than the second and has more close views of the big mountains, but at the same time has more roadwork to contend with. The Plan Chécrouit/Dolonne option descends at first through ski terrain, but as a 'plus' visits Dolonne, which is a truly charming village. This route also gives an opportunity (for those who want it) of a cablecar ride down to the valley.

TMB VARIANTE: COURMAYEUR VIA Rifugio MONTE BIANCO

Turn sharp left at the Maison Vieille refuge, and walk across the meadows to where a path leads steeply downhill among trees to a ski-lift in a clearing. Go down the bank, then turn right onto a broad slope running down to the CAI-owned

RIFUGIO MONTE BIANCO (1666m, 4½hrs), accommodation, refreshments; 66 places in dortoirs and beds; manned from June to mid-Sept (Tel 0165 86 90 97 info@rifugiomontebianco.com).

Here you come onto a road which is followed all the way into the Val Veni, with the Grandes Jorasses and Dent du Géant looking splendid ahead. About 25mins or so beyond the refuge the road is joined by another coming through the valley. Keep right, and 5mins later draw level with the little 19th-century chapel of **Notre Dame de la Guérison (1444m, 4¾hrs)** opposite the entrance to the Mont Blanc Tunnel.

Curving round the base of Mont Chétif, Val Veni is left behind and you enter the upper reaches of Val d'Aosta. When the road forks, with the left branch crossing the valley to La Saxe, keep on the right-hand option as far as **Entrélevie (1226m, 5¼hrs)**. Now cross the river (the Doire Baltéa) and the main road, and turn right into Via dei Bagni which leads into

COURMAYEUR – see main route via Dolonne.

Main route to Courmayeur via Dolonne

Passing the rifugio bear right on a track/dirt road and shortly come to a junction of tracks where you walk ahead over grass, along the left-hand side of a ski lift, then down a piste towards buildings. On reaching a house bear left, and 10mins from Maison Vieille come to the

RIFUGIO LE RANDONNEUR (1890m) 25 dortoir places and beds; open from mid-June to end of Sept (Tel 349 53 68 898; info@randonneurmb.com; www.randonneurmb.com).

About 1min beyond this privately-owned gîte leave the main track for a minor one descending past a snack bar, and shortly after come to another ski tow where you descend timber-braced steps on a narrow path winding down grass slopes. This eventually brings you to another track/dirt road where you bear left and wander down towards the Funivia Courmayeur (cablecar station). Turn left on another track which takes you to the cableway building. To the left of this you will find a narrow signed footpath which descends steeply down a wooded slope and soon joins a crossing path. Turn right to continue the steep descent among trees. About 50mins from Col Chécrouit the path brings you onto a dirt road at a hairpin bend. Immediately turn left on a continuing path. Winding through more steep woodland eventually come onto a narrow tarmac lane just above **Dolonne (1210m, 5¼hrs, accommodation, refreshments)**, an attractive stone-built village with crowded narrow streets.

Walk into the village along the Strada Chécrouit, and bear left into the main street (Via della Vittoria) where it crosses. Shortly before reaching the church a TMB sign directs the way to the right and this will lead out of Dolonne to the road linking the village with Courmayeur across the river. A splendid view shows the Aiguille (or Dent) du Géant soaring above the head of the valley. Walk down the road and across the river, and soon after go beneath the main road and out to a major junction, the Piazzale Monte Bianco, in **Courmayeur (13)** which rises in tiers above you. Both the tourist office and post office are located in the large building ahead on the

left. The bus station and public toilets are also on the left, while just ahead there's a drinking water supply and telephone kiosks. Check at the tourist office for accommodation. Should you need to cut short your TMB circuit here, buses run daily through the Mont Blanc Tunnel to Chamonix.

COURMAYEUR (1226m, 5½hrs) hotels, pensions, restaurants, banks, ATM, shops, PTT. Tourist information: AIAT Monte Bianco, Piazzale Monte Bianco 13, Courmayeur (Tel 01 65 84 20 60; courmayer@turismo.vda.it; www.lovevda.it). Lower-priced accommodation: Pensione Venezia (Tel 01 65 84 24 61); Hotel Select (Tel 01 65 84 66 61; select@courmayeurhotel.com; www.courmayeurhotel.com); Hotel Edelweiss (Tel 01 65 84 15 90; info@albergoedelweiss.it); Hotel Svizzero (Tel 01 65 84 81 70; info@hotelsvizzero.com; www.hotelsvizzero.com); Hotel Crampon (Tel 01 65 84 23 85; info@crampon.it; www.crampon.it).

A GOOD PLACE FOR A REST DAY

Despite the lively crowds who gather here, Courmayeur has a restful atmosphere, and with the soaring mountain walls blocking the northern horizon, it has an attraction all its own. 'All the great climbers of the Alps have been at Courmayeur,' wrote RLG Irving, 'and probably none has learned to climb there, except the many guides it has produced. It is a haven whence men set out for great adventures and return from them? The turning of the corner out of the deep trough below the great mountain wall, from whichever end of it you come [the Vals Veni or Ferret], brings you into a different world.'

If you plan to have a day off in Courmayeur and the weather is clear consider riding the **Funivie Monte Bianco** (cablecar) from La Palud to Point Helbronner at 3462m for tremendous high mountain views. You can then continue by gondola across 5km of the glaciated Vallée Blanche to the Aiguille du Midi (above Chamonix) and back again; a truly memorable experience.

STAGE 5

Courmayeur – Rifugio Bonatti

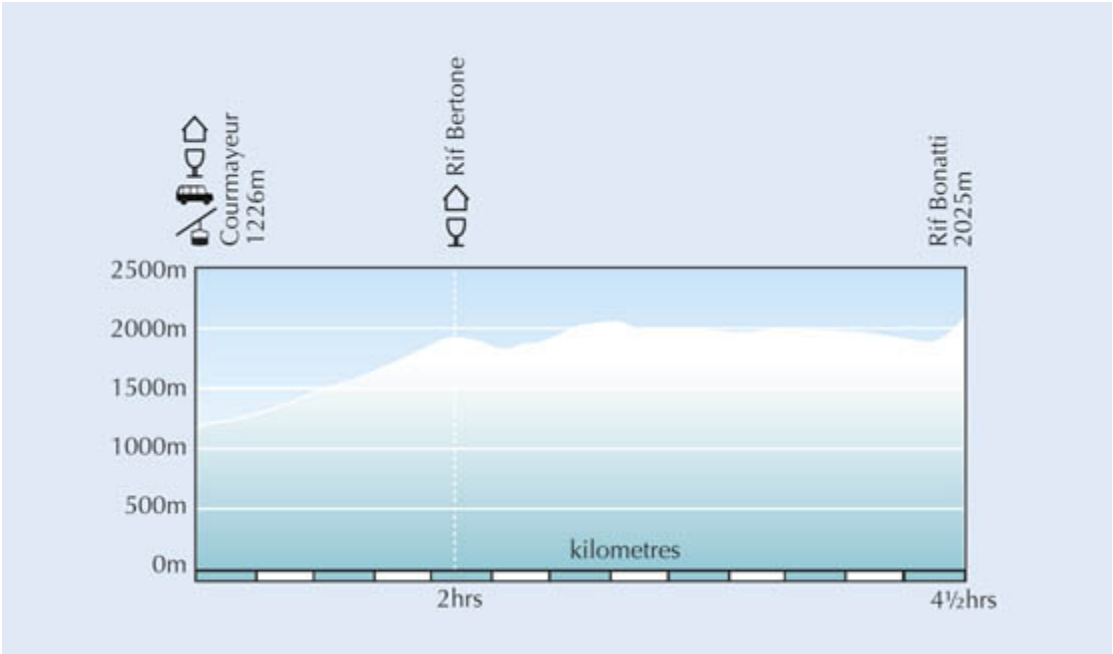
Start point	Courmayeur (1226m)
Distance	12km (16km or 14km via <i>variantes</i> 1 and 2)
Height gain	860m (1597m or 1449m)
Height loss	101m (698m or 550m by the <i>variantes</i>)
Time	4½hrs (6½–7hrs or 6–6½hrs via <i>variantes</i> 1 and 2)
High point	Tête de la Tronche 2584m (Mont de la Saxe option)
Transport option	Bus (Courmayeur – Arnuva in Val Ferret – on Stage 6)
Accommodation	Le Pré (2hrs) – privately-owned refuge (Rifugio Bertone); Rifugio Bonatti – privately-owned refuge above La Vachey
Alternative route	Villair – Val Sapin – Col Sapin

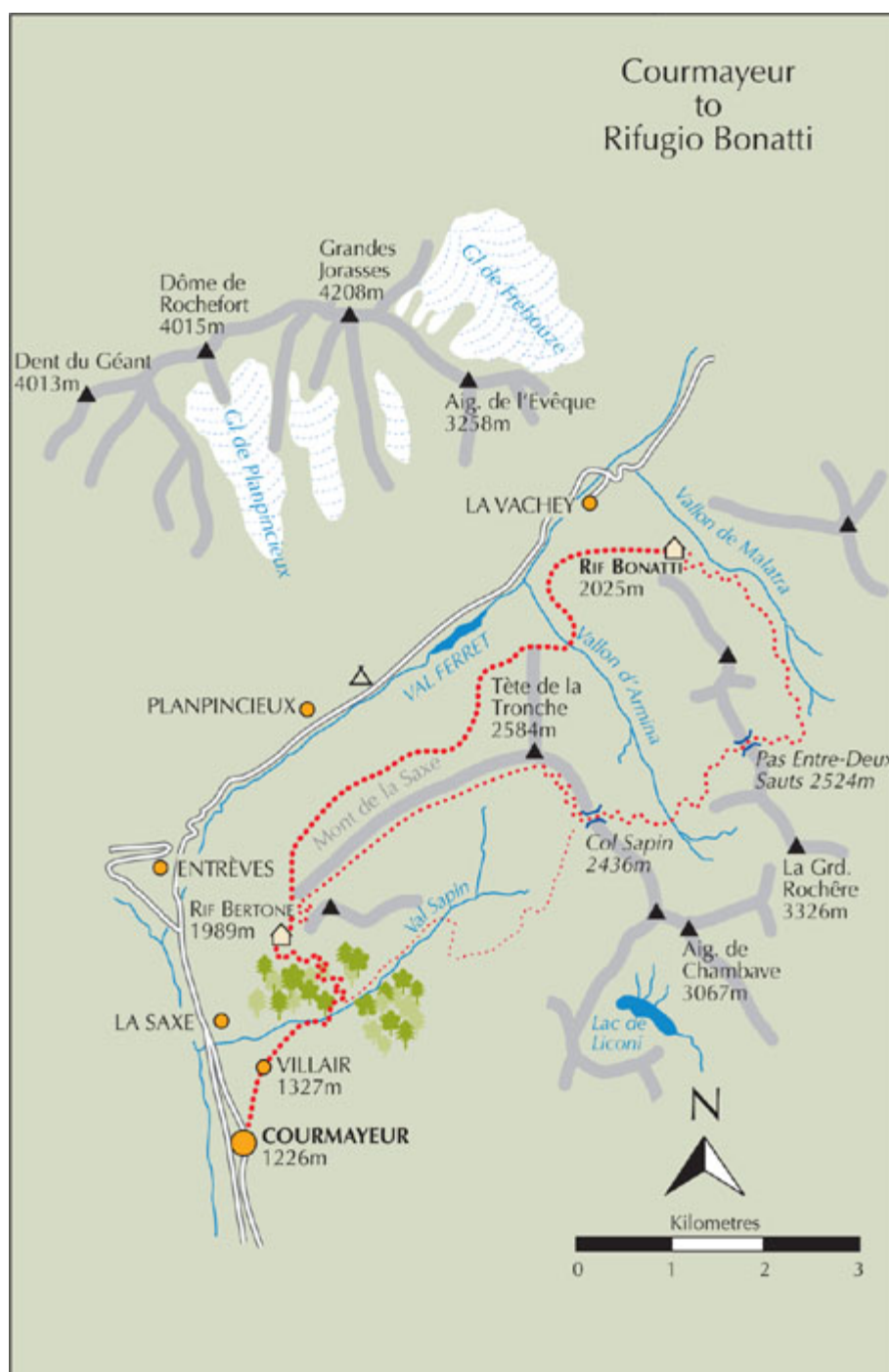
In good conditions this stage promises to be one of the highlights of the Tour of Mont Blanc.

The grandeur of yesterday's views from the high route above Val Veni are matched on this stage along the flank of Mont (or Monte) de la Saxe where an easy, undulating path can be walked at leisure with eyes forever turning to the great wall of rock and ice across the Val Ferret. A few ruined huts tell of one-time alps; in early summer alpenroses colour the slopes with scarlet; in the autumn larches add a splash of yellow and gold. The stage is a delight from start to finish.

Until 2006 the TMB followed the Mont de la Saxe crest, regarded by many as the best viewpoint from which to study the south side of the Mont Blanc range. But the walker paid for that view with physical effort, for to reach the crest involves a steep and wearisome climb of more than 1200m out of Courmayeur. As Andrew Harper said in the predecessor to this guide: 'the visual prospects for the route ? are spectacular'. That route is included here as an alternative to the newly rerouted TMB.

Another alternative option is to go through Val Sapin, which lies southeast of Mont de la Saxe, and join the main route at the col at its head. Beyond Col Sapin the way descends into the head of the Vallon d'Armina, climbs to the easy saddle of Pas Entre-Deux-Sauts and then drops into the Vallon de Malatra, on one of whose lower terraces stands the splendid Rifugio Bonatti, with a direct view of the Grandes Jorasses across the depths of Val Ferret.





Begin the day's journey in the elevated square in front of the church and walk up the narrow street on its left (between the church and guides' office); this becomes the Strada del Villair. Keep on this road as it takes you out of Courmayeur alongside neat gardens and gently up a slope between houses to the upper part of **Villair (1327m, 25mins)**, where the metalled road becomes unsurfaced. Continue along this unmade road to where it crosses a bridge and curves left. At the first right-hand hairpin, take a footpath on the left which soon brings you onto the road again. Cross directly ahead, eventually rejoining the road once more. Turn right along it. About 50 paces later the waymarked TMB path breaks off to the left (1460m, 45mins) and is signed to Rifugio Bertone.

TMB VARIANTE: VAL SAPIN – COL SAPIN

Remain on the dirt road which pushes through Val Sapin on the west side of the stream, passing between the huddled buildings of **La Trappe (1505m)** and on to Chapy. A short distance beyond this cross the stream and climb the hillside heading south then east to be joined by

another path coming from Courmayeur via La Suche. The way continues to the alp **Curru (1964m, 2hrs 20mins)**. Col Sapin is now almost 500m above to the northeast, and the path to it cuts across the hillside, crosses the stream once more and climbs in numerous zigzags to reach **Col Sapin (2436m, 3hrs 50mins)**, where it joins the Mont de la Saxe option – see [Mont de la Saxe option](#).

Main TMB Route

Having left the unmade road the way climbs through forest and a few open patches, in places very steeply and with zigzags, but it's a well-made path and, taken at a steady, unhurried pace, can be most pleasant. From the point where you leave the road it will take 1–1¼hrs to reach the complex of stone buildings of Le Pré just above the treeline and dominated by the privately-owned

RIFUGIO GIORGIO BERTONE (1989m, 2hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 55 dortoir places, 14 beds; open mid-June to end Sept (Tel 01 65 84 46 12; info@rifugiobertone.com; www.rifugiobertone.it).

Just below the rifugio a wonderful view is gained of Mont Blanc and the Aiguille Noire, as well as a bird's-eye view onto the toy-like buildings of Courmayeur, 700m below.

Continue above and to the right of the rifugio to reach a knoll at a junction with a path coming from the Val Ferret **(14)** to the left (c2030m). It is this path which now carries the route of the TMB, while the Mont de la Saxe ridge route continues above.

MONT DE LA SAXE OPTION

From the path junction climb steeply to gain the crest of Mont de la Saxe about 40mins later. From here, and all the way along the ridge to Tête de la Tronche, there's a stupendous panoramic view of the south wall of the Mont Blanc range from Col de la Seigne to the Grand Col Ferret, and in particular of the Grandes Jorasses seen across the valley to the north. (On 23 June 1865 Edward Whymper and his guides came here to study the mountain with a view to making its ascent, which they duly achieved next day. Unaccountably they went for the central summit instead of the main peak – Pointe Walker – which is only 24m higher.)

Passing avalanche fences the way leads along the grass crest heading northeast. In places the path unravels into several strands, and where it does, it's probably best to keep to the highest part of the ridge. Having passed just to the right of the 2534m Tête Bernarda a small saddle is reached, where a path drops to the left. Ignore this and keep on the TMB path, which slopes up towards the higher **Tête de la Tronche** on the righthand side of the ridge. Come onto the high point of the walk at 2584m (4hrs), then descend to a notch looking onto the steep cliffs on the east side of the ridge. The path now descends very steeply (caution advised) to **Col Sapin** (2436m, 4¼–4½hrs).

Leaving the col the path descends a little north of east into the head of the tranquil Vallon d'Armina, reaching its lowest point where another path breaks away left (an 'escape route' down to La Vachey in Val Ferret). Ignore this option and contour across the floor of the cirque, crossing several streams on the way, then angle up the grass slope on the east side of the valley below Tête de Sécheron. About 1hr from Col Sapin reach the **Pas Entre-Deux-Sauts (2524m, 5¼–5½hrs)**.

Descend into the head of the Vallon de Malatra on a gentle, meandering route over pastureland following a sometimes vague path below the slab face of the Grande Rochère. Before long the path curves leftward with Mont Dolent and Aiguille de Triolet at first standing out ahead, then the Grandes Jorasses filling the view. Keep left of the main valley stream as you wander through a delightfully flat pasture, at the end of which you drop a little towards the buildings of Alpe supérieure de Malatra (2213m) and a junction of paths. Keep left and descend on a yellow waymarked path that soon breaks into several strands where the hillside has been cut by cattle. Make towards the left-hand side of more alp buildings (Malatra on the map), just below which you come to **Rifugio Bonatti** (15).



The wild south face of the Grande Jorasses seen from Mont de la Saxe

Main TMB Route

At the path junction above Rifugio Bertone fork left to contour round the Val Ferret flank of Mont de la Saxe, gaining a magnificent view towards Col de la Seigne, with the Aiguille Noire, Mont Blanc and the Grandes Jorasses supporting a succession of glaciers, snowfields and abrupt rock walls. The path develops as a balcony trail among juniper, bilberry and thin larchwoods, then across open meadows with breathtaking views every step of the way. When the path forks above the ruins of Alp Leuchey (1938m; 2½hrs), continue ahead across pastureland, and 30mins later come to the long concrete cattle byre of Alp Lèche (1929m). The way now twists uphill, then angles across the hillside.

Turning a spur into the **Vallon d'Armina**, descend to the stream and cross on a sturdy timber footbridge, then go down towards the few buildings of Alp Arminaz (2033m) where the path suddenly turns right, climbs above a ruin, and joins another path (3½hrs). The TMB forks left to angle round the hillside on a gentle descent, soon among larchwoods before gaining Alp Sécheron. Pass directly above the buildings and continue ahead, coming to yet another junction (the last one of the day) about 20mins later. Turn right and briefly climb the slope to reach the well-appointed, privately-owned

RIFUGIO BONATTI (2025m, 4½hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 85 dortoir places; manned from March to April, and June to end of Sept (Tel 01 65 18 55 523; rifugiobonatti@gmail.com; www.rifugiobonatti.it).



Viewed from Rifugio Bonatti, Mont Blanc turns bronze with the sun's last glow

Should the rifugio be full, return to the path junction below the hut, and continue down the trail into the Val Ferret. Bear left and wander down the road to

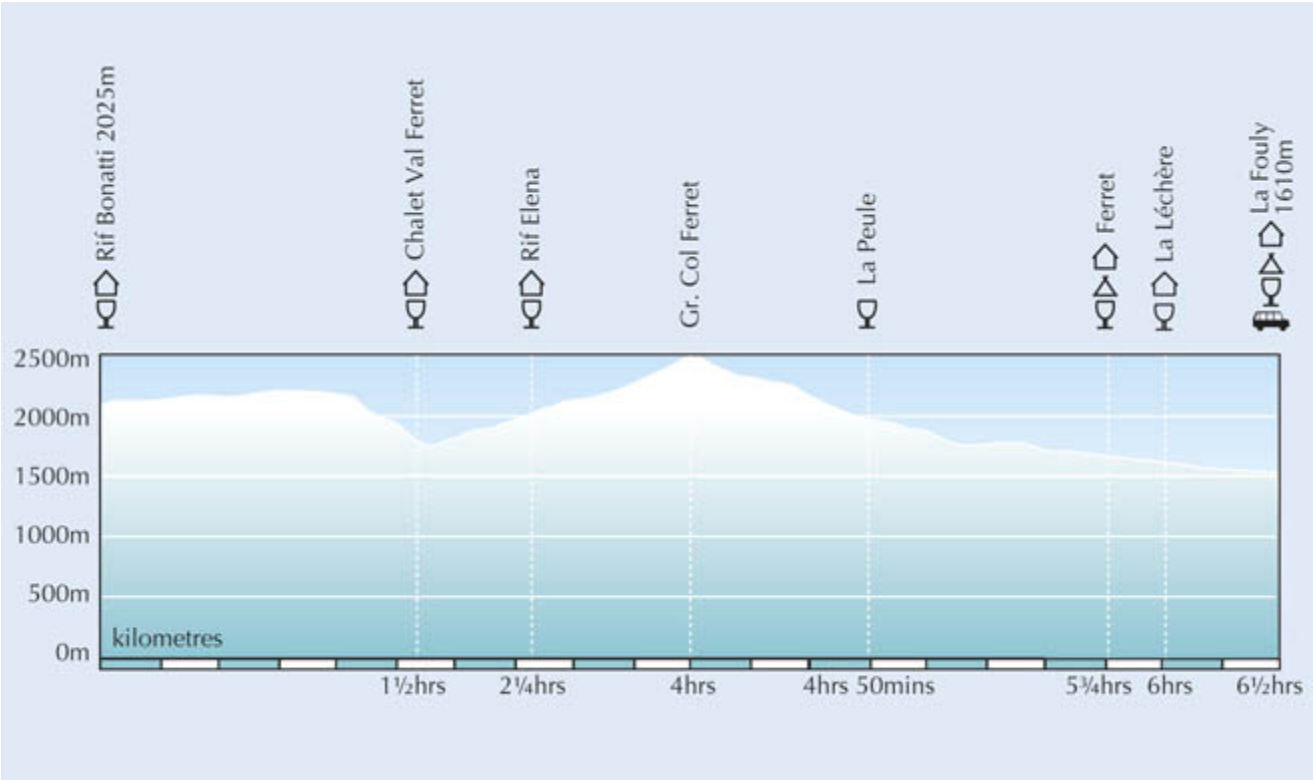
LA VACHEY (1642m), about 1–1¼hrs from Rifugio Bonatti. Overnight accommodation may be had at the Hotel Lavachey, 21 beds; open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 01 65 86 97 23, www.lavachey.com).

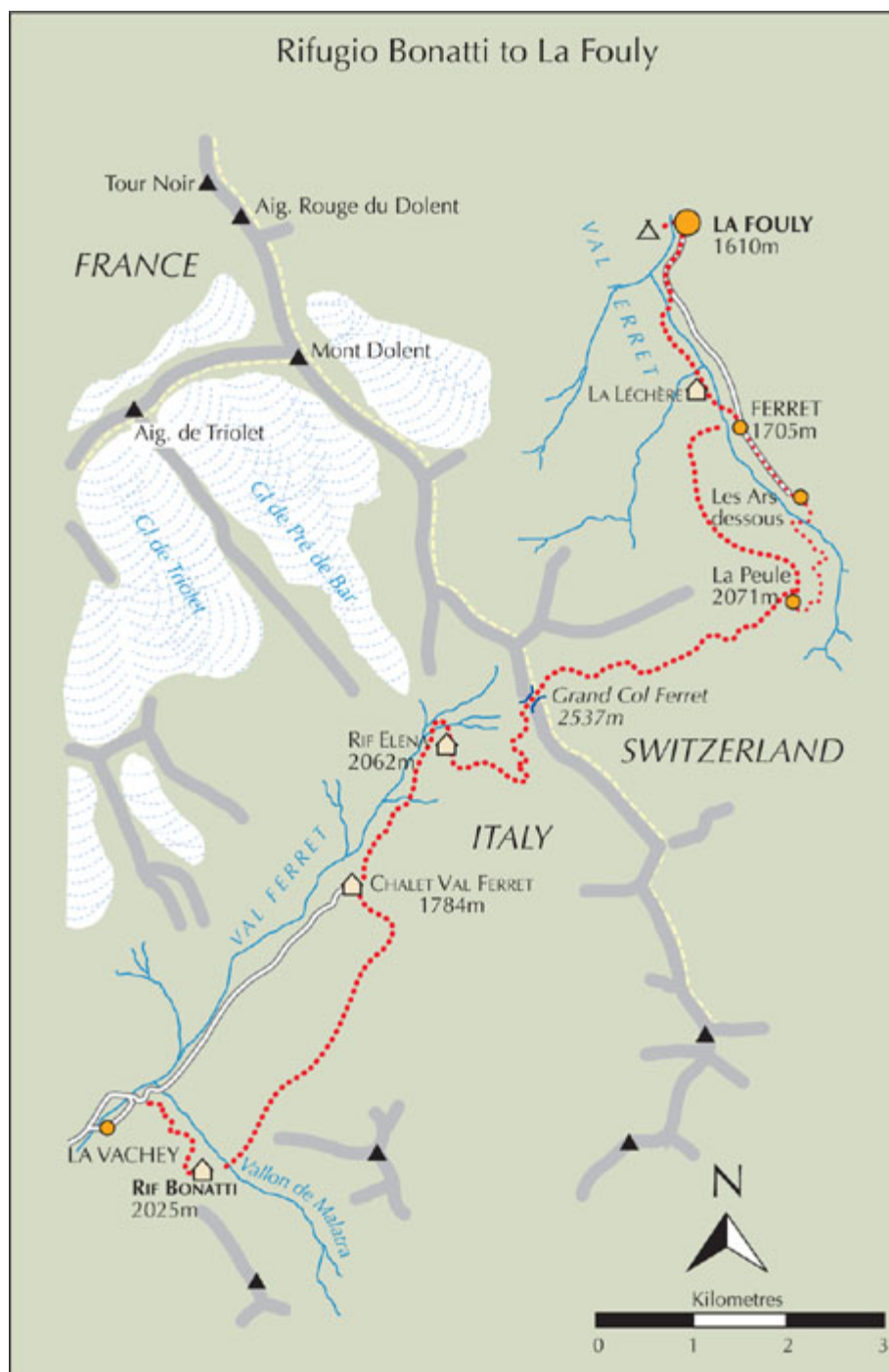
STAGE 6*Rifugio Bonatti – Grand Col Ferret – La Fouly*

Start point	Rifugio Bonatti (2025m)
Distance	20km
Height gain	895m
Height loss	1410m
Time	6–6½hrs
High point	Grand Col Ferret (2537m)
Transport options	Bus (La Vachey – Arnuva); Bus (Ferret – La Fouly)
Accommodation	Arnuva (1½hrs) – hotel; Pré de Bar (2¼hrs) – refuge; Ferret (Switzerland – 5¾–6hrs) – hotel; La Léchère (6hrs) – gîte d'étape; La Fouly – hotels, gîte, camping

The crossing of Grand Col Ferret takes the TMB out of Italy, into Switzerland and along the eastern edge of the Mont Blanc range. It's another fine route, for the day starts with a glorious contouring trail then descends into the Val Ferret, followed by an easy walk upvalley to Rifugio Elena, where the climb to the pass begins. This ascent is not too demanding under normal summer conditions, and will probably be no more taxing than the route to Col de la Seigne three days ago, while the way down into the Swiss Val Ferret on the far side is over rolling pastureland also without undue difficulties.

Among the highlights of this stage will undoubtedly be the view from the col looking back along the length of the Vals Ferret and Veni to the distant Col de la Seigne, a view partly framed by monstrous buttresses of rock. This will be the last sighting of the Grandes Jorasses for several days, for the next time this big block of mountain comes into view will be from the north, on the approach to La Flégère on Stage 10. The intimacy of the big mountains will be lost in the Swiss Val Ferret, although outliers of the range are seen – and seen to good effect – on the way to, and from, La Fouly. But this valley has other characteristics to enjoy: it has flower meadows and chalets with window boxes bursting with geraniums and petunias; it has milky streams, the clanging of cowbells, neat patches of forest and hamlets that appear to be untouched by passing centuries. Val Ferret lives up to its reputation as one of the most idyllic of Swiss valleys, and entry from the south enables the walker to make its acquaintance by stealth.







A short distance below the Grand Col Ferret a brief diversion from the main path leads to a view of the Swiss Val Ferret

Out of the rifugio go up the slope to the Malatra alp huts, and bear left on a path which makes a traverse of the hillside. Three streams are crossed, the second of which comes crashing over a series of cascades, but after the third stream crossing the path curves leftwards and slopes down to the derelict alp buildings of Gioé (2007m). Go between the buildings, and when the path forks keep straight ahead. Reaching a high point on a corner, 20mins from the rifugio, the path then slopes downhill with a fine view of the Pré-de-Bar glacier's big moraine wall ahead.

The hillside here is a delight of alpenrose, bilberry and larch, and views are exciting as the trail rises and falls towards the head of the Val Ferret, crossing several minor streams along the way. In a little over an hour you come to an alp building at a junction of paths. Bear left and descend to another fork where you keep ahead (the right-hand option), eventually reaching the valley floor by the small

CHALET VAL FERRET (1784m, 1½hrs) bar/restaurant, 14 beds; open June to end of Sept (Tel 01 65 84 49 59; info@chaletvalferret.com; www.chaletvalferret.com).

Walk along the tarmac approach road for about 100m, turn right to cross the river and follow the track to a parking area, on the far side of which a path carries the continuing TMB to Rifugio Elena and the Grand Col Ferret. The path climbs steeply in places, takes you past a group of ruins, crosses a stream on a footbridge, and then even more steeply up a slope to gain

RIFUGIO ELENA (2062m, 2¼hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 128 dortoir places, 15 beds; manned mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 01 65 84 46 88; rifugioelena@virgilio.it).

The rifugio has been built into the hillside for protection – a wise precaution since the previous Elena hut was destroyed by avalanche in the 1950s. From it one looks across the valley onto the Glacier de Pré de Bar, which sweeps down from Mont Dolent. The upper névé basin of this glacier is rimmed by a ridge linking that multi-frontiered peak with Aiguille de Triolet; then two banks of rock squeeze the icefall before releasing it to spew the rounded snout into a wash of grey moraine debris. Because of its accessibility and easy viewing, and the refreshment facilities afforded by the Elena rifugio, the rather drab Pré de Bar glacier attracts hordes of visitors during the summer.

Two cols Ferret cross the frontier ridge above the Elena hut, but it is the southernmost (and higher) pass that is adopted by the TMB. Behind the hut the well-made and justifiably popular path turns away from the glacier and slants to the right across the hillside, then in a series of zigzags that lead up and past a few ruins. Beyond these the way angles up a little further

before turning left and climbing steeply towards the pass. A little under 2hrs from the Elena rifugio, come onto the watershed of the **Grand Col Ferret (2537m, 4hrs)** for your first view into Switzerland, which is rather unprepossessing by contrast with the backward view. Only the snowy Grand Combin in the distance is worthy of attention to the east, but looking northwest along the frontier ridge Mont Dolent **(16)** is of interest, as is the Aiguille de Triolet to its left. However, it is the view back down through the Val Ferret to Val Veni and the distant Col de la Seigne that gives most value. An orientation table helps identify major points in the panorama.

Snow often lies on the Swiss side of the col well into the summer, where the gentle grass slopes are dipped with hollows and scoops. The way is invariably marked. At first veering left, then curving round to the east, about 8mins from the col note a minor (unmarked) path striking left ahead away from the main TMB. If you follow this a short distance it brings you to a wonderful viewpoint overlooking, through a dip in the grassy ridge, almost the full length of the Swiss Val Ferret.

Regaining the main path, the way angles across broad open slopes which sweep down into the combe of Revers de la Peule. The path keeps high above this, however, and about 50mins after leaving the col it brings you to the summer dairy farm of

ALPAGE DE LA PEULE (2071m, 4hrs 50mins) simple accommodation, refreshments; 30 places; open in summer (Tel 027 783 10 44; coppey.lapeule@dransnet.ch; www.lapeulaz.skyrock.com).



Looking back on the high trail between La Peule and Ferret

The TMB formerly continued its descent into the Val Ferret by following the farm road all the way from La Peule. This has now become a *variante*, an easy walk described in the box below. The main TMB now takes a higher and more scenic route, contouring along the hillside before descending steeply to the valley between Ferret and the gîte La Léchère. If visibility is poor, or there's heavy rain, take the *variante*. Otherwise the main route is highly recommended.

Main TMB Route

At the first alp building of La Peule turn sharp left onto a narrow path cutting across the pastures. This is signed to Ferret and La Léchère. After contouring for a while, the trail turns a spur among bilberries to gain a tremendous view of Mont Dolent, Tour Noir and their glaciers, with the Val Ferret stretching to the north. Now sloping downhill, cross a narrow gully, then rise again. About

40mins from La Peule enter the combe of Les Creuses (headed by the Tête de Ferret) where you come to a low concrete hut and a footpath sign directing the way downhill to La Léchère.

TMB VARIANTE

From La Peule take the unsurfaced farm road that winds downhill, and after about 30mins cross a bridge spanning the Drance de Ferret at about 1775m. Walk up the slope to another road just below the dairy farm of Les Ars dessous (5hrs 25mins). Walk down the road for about 20mins to reach the little hamlet of

FERRET (1705m, 5¾-6hrs) accommodation, refreshments; buses via La Fouly to Champex and Orsières. Accommodation at Hotel Col de Fenêtre: 18 dortoir places, 17 beds; open June to end Sept (Tel 027 783 11 88, bertrandmurisier@bluewin.ch).

For the continuing route to La Fouly, immediately before coming to the first of Ferret's buildings, take a path on the left which descends to a footbridge spanning the river. Over this turn right on a riverside trail and wander downstream through light woodland. On reaching a more substantial bridge over a side stream, you rejoin the main TMB.

Descend to a glade of larches, below which there's a junction of paths (about 15mins from the concrete hut). The right-hand path is the one to take if you need accommodation or refreshments at **Ferret**, which you can see below on the right bank of the Drance de Ferret. The left-hand option descends very steeply to a substantial footbridge spanning the stream draining the Creuses combe. It is here that the alternative route from La Peule rejoins the main TMB.

Cross the bridge, and 5mins later note a narrow signed path cutting up the left-hand hillside to the

GÎTE DE LA LÉCHÈRE (6hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 27 dortoir places; open June to end Sept (Tel 079 433 49 78).

Unless you plan to visit La Léchère continue ahead and follow a track ahead which is joined by another soon after. Rising a little and turning a bend, pass a building where a signpost directs the TMB path to the right, dropping through a sloping meadow and into trees. Through these you come to a bridge over the river. Cross to the road and turn left. A few minutes later enter the small village of **La Fouly (17)**, with its glorious outlook west into a cirque of mountains crowned by Mont Dolent and the Tour Noir.



The tiny chapel at Ferret

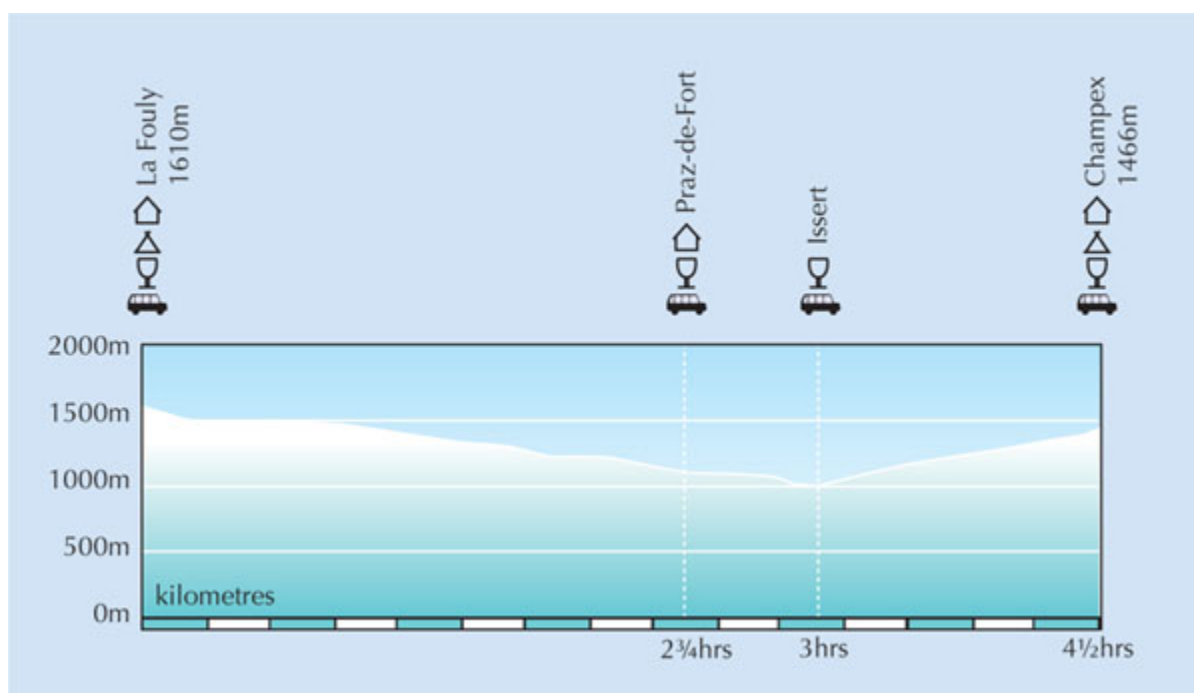
LA FOULY (1610m, 6½hrs) hotels, gîte, camping, shops, ATM, restaurants, PTT, buses to Orsières and Champex; tourist office (Tel 027 783 27 17; www.st-bernard.ch). Lower-priced accommodation: Chalet Le Dolent, 65 dortoir places, 10 beds, open all year (Tel 027 783 29 31; info@dolent.ch; www.dolent.ch); Gîte Les Girolles, 60 beds, open all year (Tel 027 783 18 75; lesgirolles@netplus.ch); Auberge des Glaciers, 34 dortoir places, 22 beds, open June to October (Tel 027 783 11 71; info@aubergedesglaciers.ch); Hotel Edelweiss, 25 dortoir places, 45 beds, open end of May to end of Sept (Tel 027 783 26 21, hotel.edelweiss@st-bernard.ch).

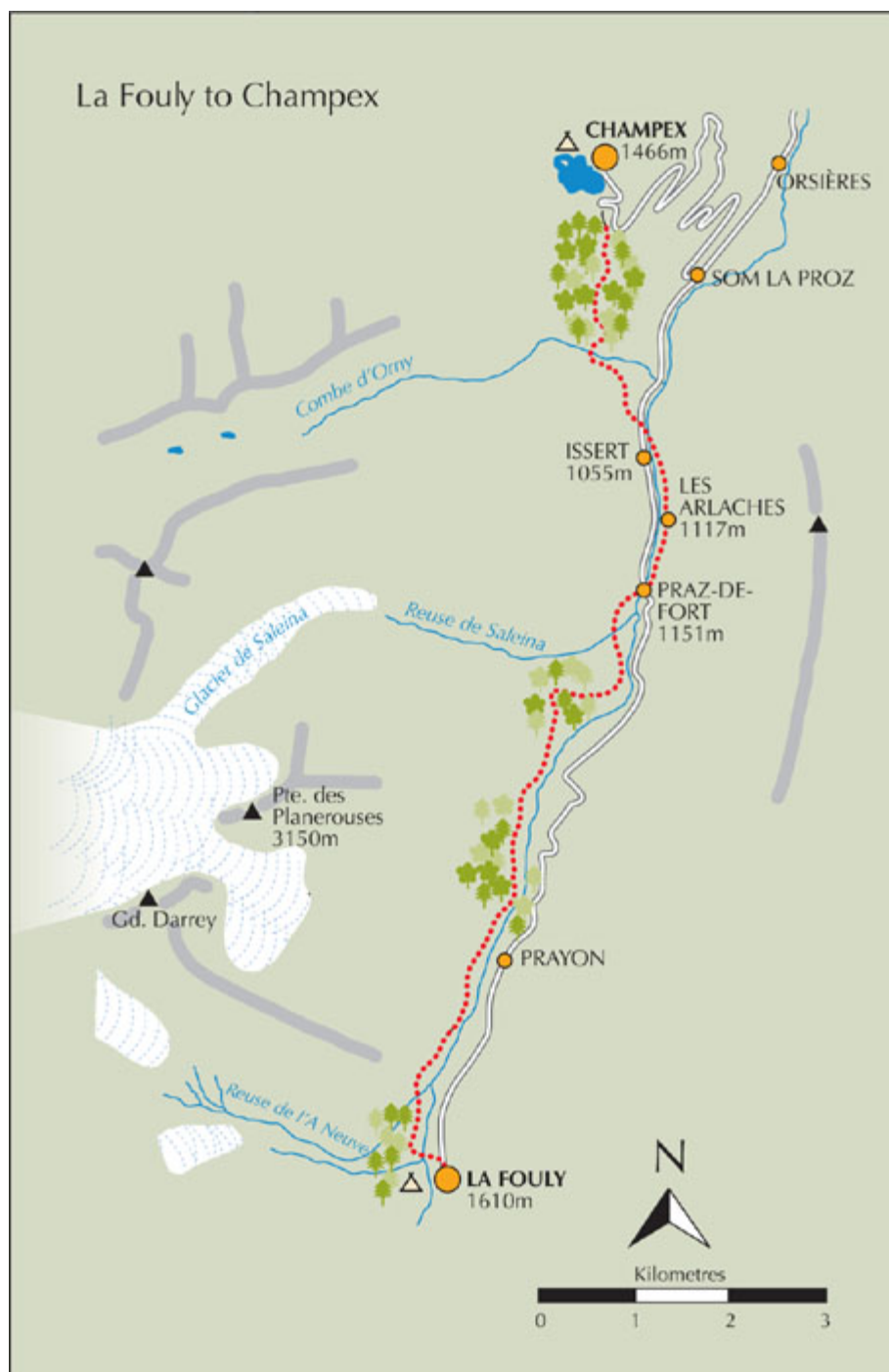
STAGE 7

La Fouly – Champex

Start point	La Fouly (1610m)
Distance	15km
Height gain	420m
Height loss	565m
Time	4–4½hrs
High point	Champex (1466m)
Accommodation	Prayon (40mins) – pension; Champex – hotels, pensions, gîte, camping; Val d'Arpette (+ 45mins Alt. Stage 8) – hotel/dortoir, camping; Champex d'en Haut (+ 30mins Stage 8) – hotel, gîte
Note	Alternative route: Bus (La Fouly – Champex)

This is the easiest stage of the TMB, and with a modest amount of height gain and loss the day can be taken at a leisurely pace. With neither passes to cross nor high and remote country to traverse, it's a valley walk throughout. But that is not to say it's without interest. On the contrary: here we experience the pastoral nature of a Swiss mountain valley, where the way of life of the local farming communities appears at first glance to have been barely touched by modern technology. As Walt Unsworth commented in his account of the TMB in *Classic Walks of the World*: 'the old ways still carry weight, and it seems appropriate somehow that in this slightly unreal world the chief produce should be strawberries'. Elsewhere dairy cattle graze the pastures, meadows lie striped behind the scythe, and the old dark-timbered barns send out the rich fragrance of warm hay. For the most part, glacierhung mountains are hidden from view.





Walk through the village along the road as far as the Grand Hotel du Val Ferret, where a footpath descends on the left among larches, crosses a track and continues across the river by a sluice. Turn right on a service road, and about 120m later bear right on a continuing TMB track through woodland. About 15mins from La Fouly cross a meadow below the 400m high Amône Slab on which climbers can sometimes be seen in action. A track swings right here to cross the river, but we keep ahead and in another 20mins or so come to a junction of tracks in a clearing where one route cuts off to the right and is signed to Prayon. **Note** By taking this alternative route accommodation may be had at Restaurant du Dolent (7 beds; open June–Sept; Tel 027 783 11 76).

Ignoring this alternative, keep ahead where the track gently loses height to another fork by a bridge at 1370m. About 10mins later leave the track at a hairpin where a signed footpath soon rises along the wooded hillside, and after a while comes to an open, slightly exposed section safeguarded with a fixed chain, then continues among trees, descending at first with zigzags, then less steeply.

Approaching the as yet unseen Saleina tributary, the TMB turns right at a signed junction onto the ancient lateral moraine of the fast-receding Saleina glacier. This is the Crête de Saleina, a wooded causeway topped by a good path which follows the crest for several minutes before sloping downhill to a dirt road near a bridge. Bear left, and keep ahead when the road becomes metalled, then cross the mouth of the tributary valley. Remain on the road between chalets, cross the Reuse de Saleina and take the right branch when it forks. The TMB now slopes gently downhill, passing the old houses and barns of

PRAZ-DE-FORT (1151m, 2hrs) refreshments, PTT, grocery.

Turn right on the main road, cross the river then bear left on the waymarked route through meadows leading in another 10mins to the charming little hamlet of **Les Arlaches (1117m)**. Keep ahead through this hamlet, with its timeless chalets and barns crowded one against another, after which the next village, Issert, can be seen ahead astride the main road a little under 10mins walk away. The main track leads down to the road on the village outskirts, but the TMB cuts off to the right at a T-junction on an alternative track which crosses a bridge in the centre of **Issert (1055m, 2½hrs, refreshments)**.



An old flower-adorned house in Issert

Turn right along the main road, and about 100m beyond the last buildings a signpost directs the TMB left (Champex 1½hrs) along a lane, over a stream, up a track, then on a footpath which soon enters forest. After 2½hrs of walking mostly downhill or along the flat since La Fouly, the prospect of a 1½hr climb to Champex comes as something of a shock. In truth the ascent is modest by comparison with much that has gone before, so you should settle into a comfortable stride and enjoy this mostly forested walk. There are numerous path junctions, but the way is either obvious or waymarked with a yellow diamond outlined in black. The route has been adopted as the Sentier des Champignons, and is decorated with a number of wood carvings that include mushrooms, squirrels, an eagle and so on. After about 3½hrs the path brings you above two small chalets where, on a bend, there's a water supply, picnic table and a bird's-eye view onto Orsières. As you draw close to Champex the TMB brings you to the road linking Orsières with Champex. Cross with care, bear left and rounding a bend take a signed footpath rising above the road. This takes you through woodland before coming onto a minor service road near Hotel Bellevue. A few paces before the hotel, cross an open space on the left to join another

service road. Turn left and shortly after you will arrive at the southeastern end of **Champex (18)**.

CHAMPEX (1466m, 4–4½hrs) hotels, pensions, gîte, camping; restaurants, shops, PTT, tourist information (Tel 027 775 23 83, champexlac@saint-bernard.ch; www.champex.info). Lower-priced accommodation: Pension En Plein Air, 48 dortoir places, 25 beds, open all year (Tel 027 783 23 50; pensionenpleinair@bluewin.ch); Au Club Alpin, 25 dortoir places, open all year (Tel 027 783 11 61); Chalet du Jardin Alpin, 8 dortoir places, 13 beds, self-catering only, open May to end Oct (Tel 027 783 12 17; chalet@flore-alpe.ch); Camping Les Rocailles, open all year (Tel 027 783 19 79), is located at the top end of the village. Other accommodation options lie on the route of Stage 8 (+ 30mins) and Alternative Stage 8 (+ 45mins). Refer to the appropriate sections for details.

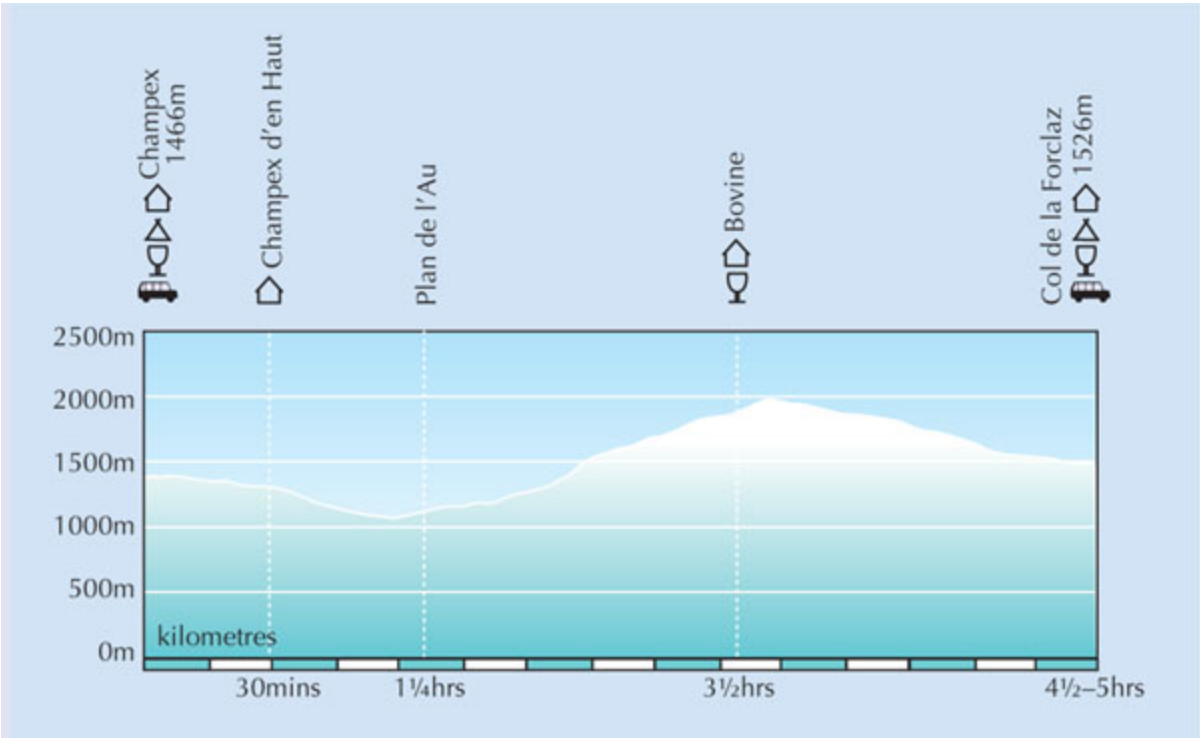
STAGE 8*Champex – Alp Bovine – Col de la Forclaz*

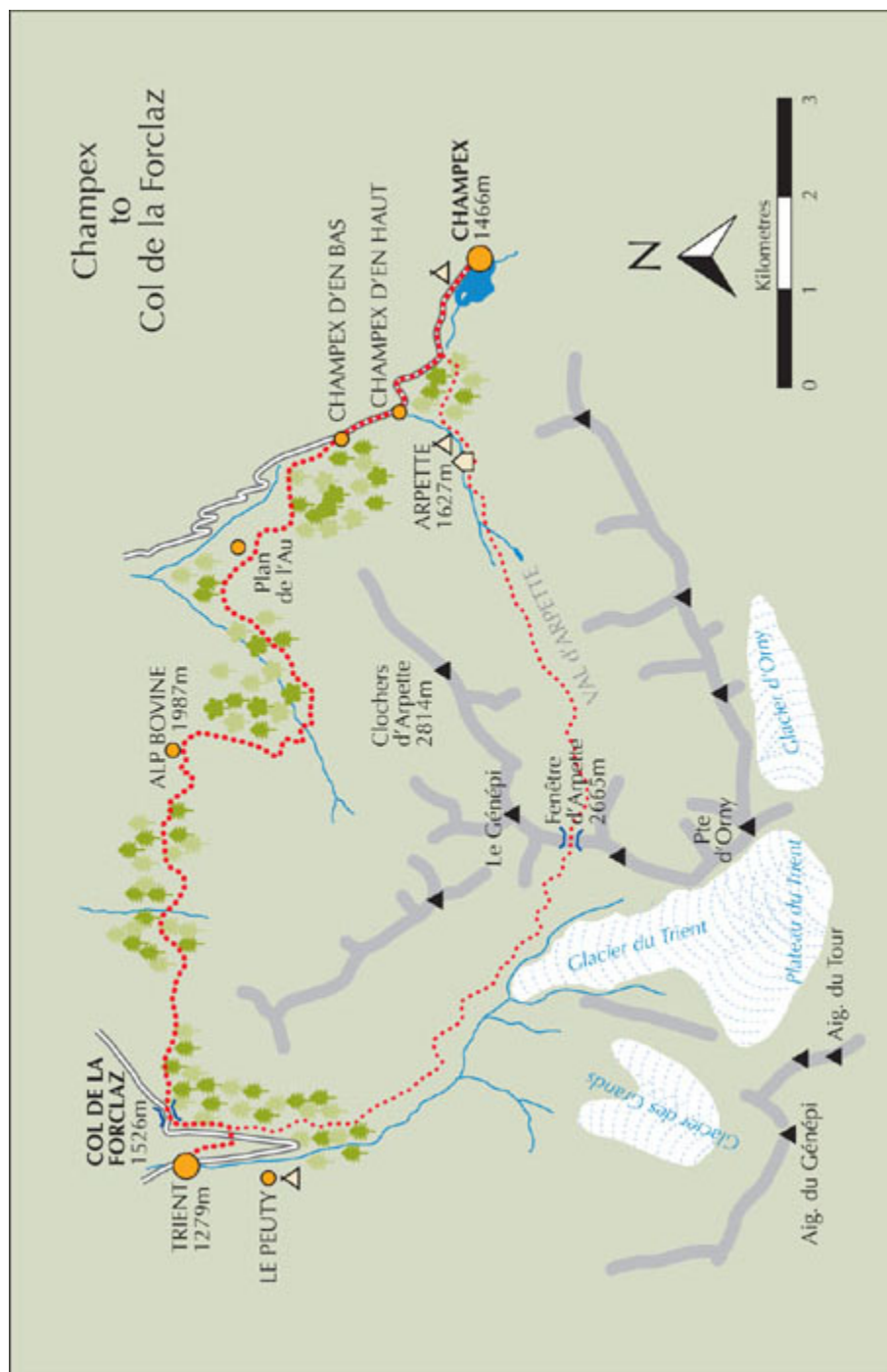
Start point	Champex (1466m)
Distance	16km
Height gain	742m
Height loss	682m
Time	4½–5hrs
High point	Collet Portalo (2040m)
Transport option	Postbus and train (Champex – Orsières – Martigny – Forclaz)
Accommodation	Champex d'en Haut (30mins) – gîte, hotel; Bovine (3¼hrs) – emergency dortoir only; Col de la Forclaz – hotel/dortoir, camping; Trient (+ 30mins) – dortoirs; Le Peuty (+ 45mins) – gîte, camping
Alternative route	Champex – Fenêtre d'Arpette – Forclaz (see Alternative Stage 8)

The Fenêtre d'Arpette route to Col de la Forclaz – Alternative Stage 8 – is a much tougher, but more spectacular option that should only be considered if the forecast is for calm, settled weather.

The stage described here is the easier of the two routes to Col de la Forclaz; an undulating walk that makes a loop round the northern slopes of a rocky spur projecting, in essence, from the Pointe d'Orny. Study of the IGN map shows the rumpled nature of this route. It curves, dips and rises over unsettled contours and in and out of indents in the hillside. There are neat meadows, patches of forest, rough combes and high alpine pastures leading to the simple alp buildings of Bovine, which look down onto Martigny in the Rhône valley and across to mountains of the Bernese Alps.

Refreshments and emergency accommodation are available at the Bovine alp, while the hotel at Col de la Forclaz provides two-tier accommodation with bedrooms and dormitories, and facilities for campers too. Accommodation is also available in Trient, a small village in the valley below and to the west of Forclaz, and at nearby Le Peuty, both of which are on one of the optional TMB routes of Stage 9.





Walk up the road leading out of Champex, passing the campsite on your right and, above this, the La Broya chairlift on the left. Continue for a few more minutes, then turn left at a junction on a minor road. About 20mins after leaving Champex pass the Bon-Abri gîte, seen to the right. This is part of the small community of

CHAMPEX D'EN HAUT (1440m, 20mins) accommodation: Chalet Bon-Abri, 33 dortoir places, 42 beds, open all year (Tel 027 783 14 23, contact@gite-bonabri.com; www.gite-bonabri.com); Hotel-Club Sunways, 77 beds, open Dec to April and June to Sept (Tel 027 783 11 22; hotel@sunways.ch).

When the road forks branch right to descend to a lower road at a four-way junction. Turn left and soon pass the string of chalets at **Champex d'en Bas (1340m)** in another 15mins, below which open meadows make this a very pleasant stretch to wander along. At the far end of the meadows turn left on a track where a sign indicates the way to Plan de l'Au and Bovine. After passing a few chalets a footpath leads through woodland and out to a narrow metalled

road. Turn left and 2mins later come to the farm buildings of **Plan de l'Au (1330m, 1¼hrs, refreshments)** with a view into the Rhône valley.

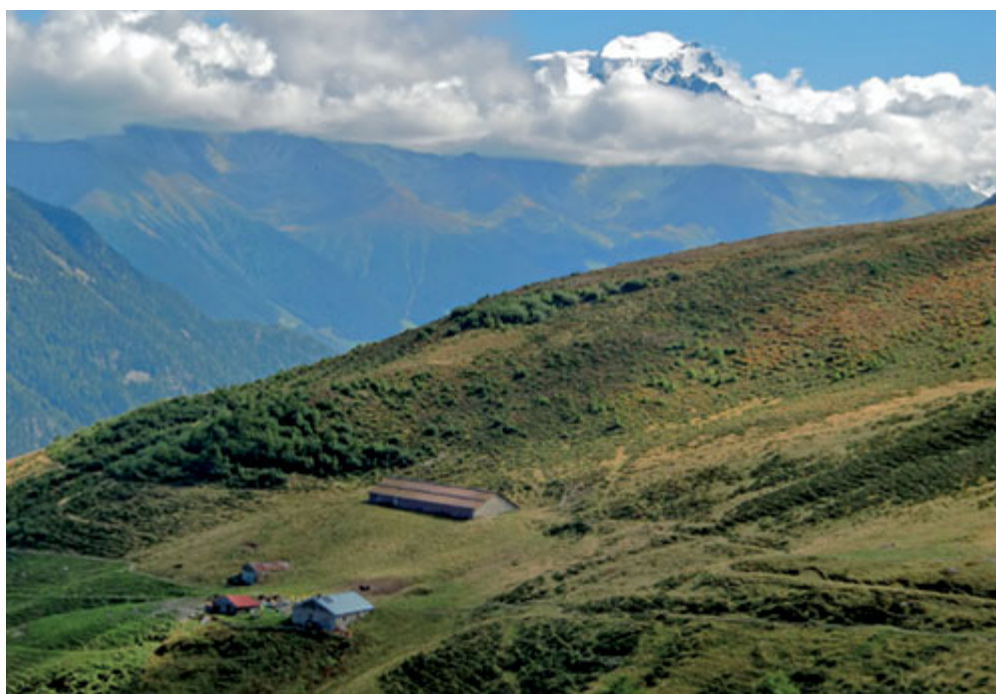
From here the road is an unsurfaced 4×4 track rising steadily for another 20mins or so, after which it curves left at a gateway and narrows to a footpath. [In the summer of 2012 a new path was created which now makes a more gently graded ascent to Alp Bovine. Research indicates that this is to be the new 'official' TMB. Sadly it will miss some really attractive sections enjoyed by the 'original' route which still exists and is described here.](#) The original TMB now climbs into the wooded combe of La Jure. There are several streams to cross, and as you gain height the vegetation changes, with bilberries lining the steep and rocky path. High above, a craggy ridge links the Clochers d'Arpette with Le Génepi.

Having climbed above tree level the way curves right (north), crosses a final stream and angles gently across an open slope. On a clear day the snowy mass of the Grand Combin can be seen to the southeast, the Dents du Midi to the northwest, and steeply below the Rhône valley runs a straight furrow below the range of the Bernese Alps. Turning a spur of the Pointe Ronde, the path now curves west to gain a first sighting of the buildings of

ALP BOVINE (1987m, 3¼hrs, emergency dortoir accommodation, refreshments).

Alp Bovine is located on a gentle slope of pasture facing northeast along the Rhône valley, providing a contrast between the pastoral life of the traditional alp farmer and the modern, high-tech agriculturalist with his orchards and vineyards 1500m below. Bovine is a working dairy farm, but the farmer's income is supplemented by refreshments served to passing walkers. Simple dortoir accommodation may be available here.

Although this is not the highest point of the walk, most of the day's demands are now over, for there's only a short rise of just 53m to achieve beyond the alp buildings, where the path leads up to a gate in a fence on the edge of larch and pinewoods a few minutes' walk away. This is the so-called **Collet Portalo (2040m, 3½hrs)**. Pause for a moment to enjoy a last view back to the Grand Combin. Once through the gate the pleasant woodland path is mostly downhill to Col de la Forclaz, passing on the way another group of alp buildings (La Giète 1884m) on the left. On occasion a brief view is gained through the trees to Martigny on a bend in the Rhône valley, and of the road which snakes its way up through the Martigny Combe to Forclaz.



The Bovine alp, with the Grand Combin in the distance floating among the clouds

At last the path emerges from woodland with the **Col de la Forclaz (19)** just ahead.

COL DE LA FORCLAZ (1526m, 4½–5hrs) refreshments, shop, bus to Martigny and Trient, accommodation in Hotel du Col de la Forclaz, 40 dortoir places, 35 beds, camping, open mid-Dec to Nov (Tel 027 722 26 88; colforclazhotel@bluewin.ch; www.coldelaforclaz.ch).

Note Dortoir accommodation is also available in Trient (+ 30mins) and Le Peuty – also camping (+ 45mins) in the Vallée du Trient below to the west. See [Stage 9](#) below for details.

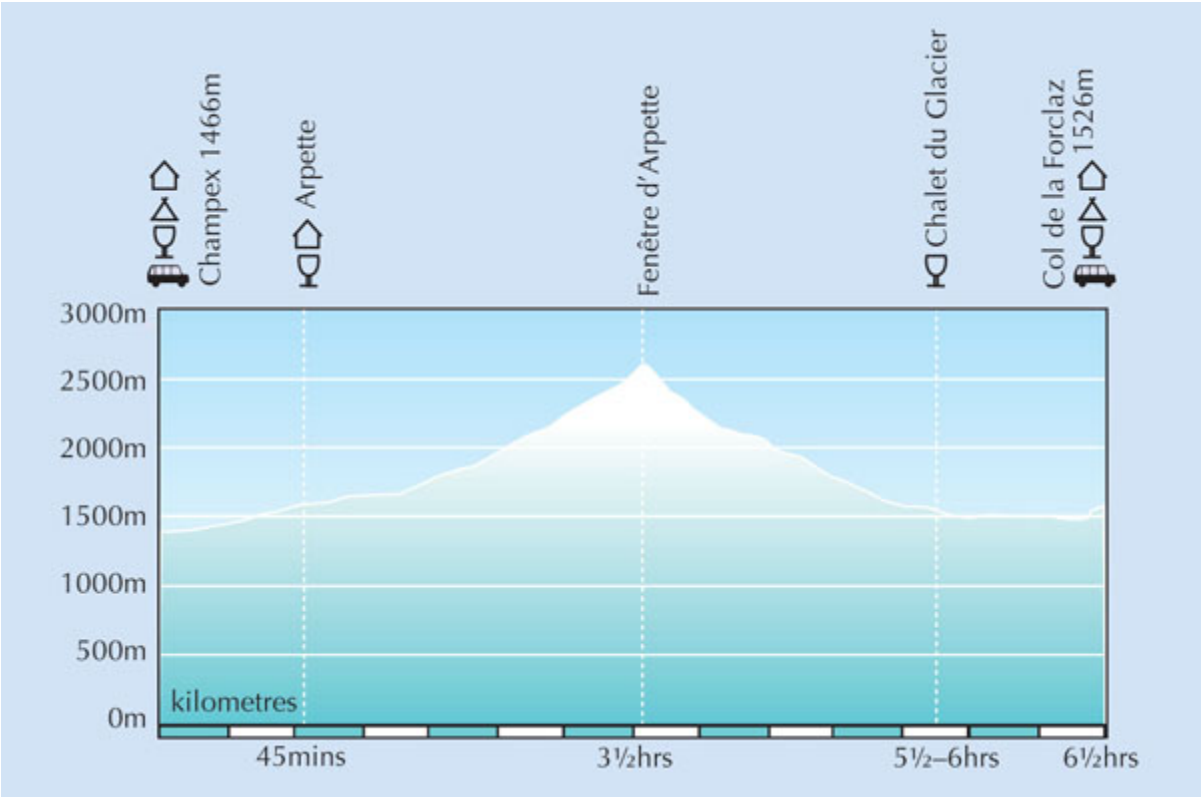
ALTERNATIVE STAGE 8*Champex – Fenêtre d'Arpette – Col de la Forclaz*

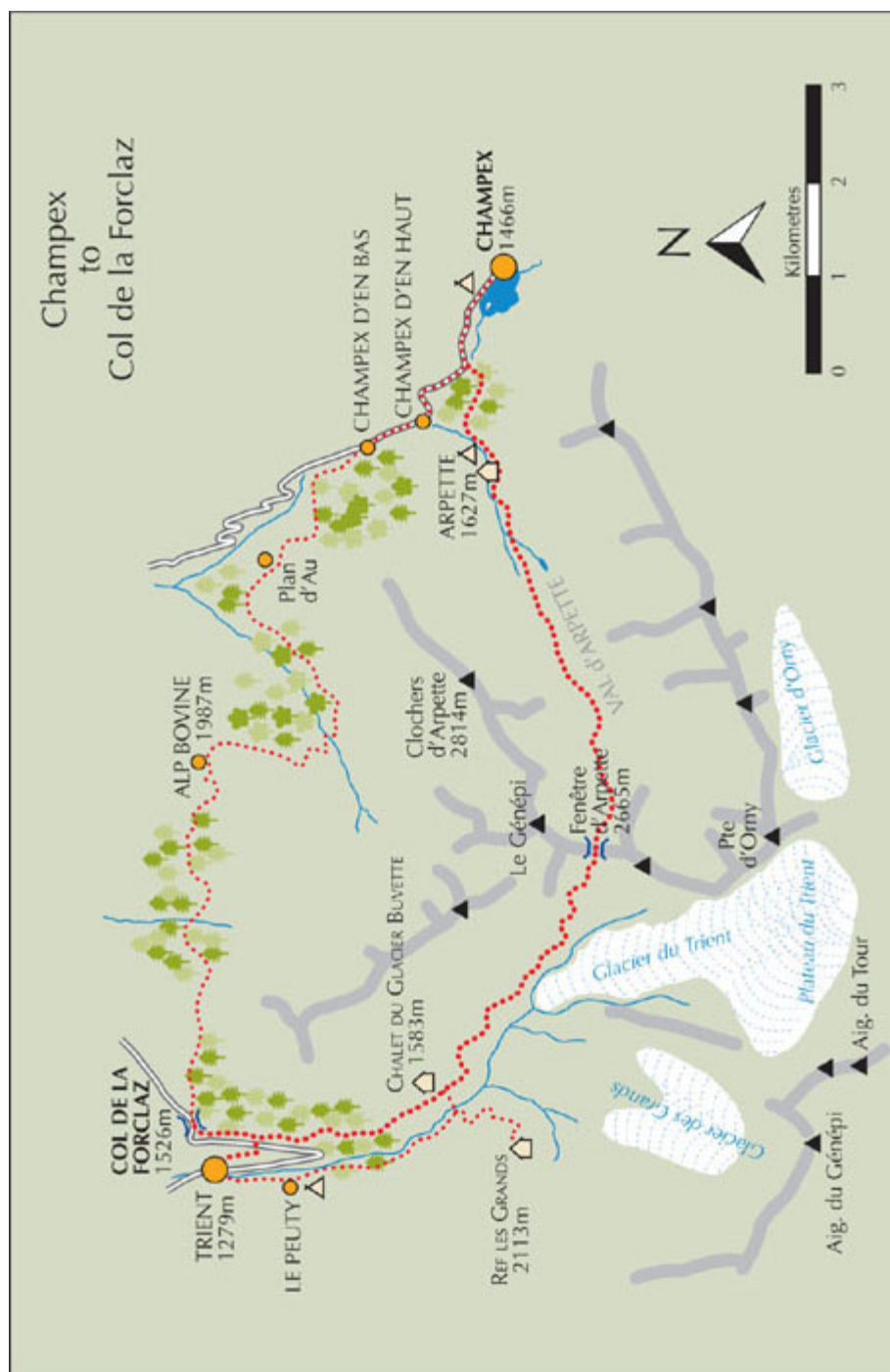
Start point	Champex (1466m)
Distance	14km
Height gain	1199m
Height loss	1139m
Time	6½hrs
High point	Fenêtre d'Arpette (2665m)
Accommodation	Arpette (45mins) – hotel/dortoir, camping; Le Peuty (6¼hrs) – gîte, camping; Trient (6½hrs) – dortoirs; Les Grands (7hrs) – CAS refuge; Col de la Forclaz – hotel/dortoir, camping
Alternative route	Champex – Bovine – Col de la Forclaz (see Stage 8)

A note of warning before setting out: the crossing should not be attempted other than in good conditions and with a forecast of settled weather. In the event of neither of these provisos being met, you are advised to use Stage 8, the 'Bovine' route described above.

Along with Col des Fours (see *variante* on Stage 2), which shares the same altitude, the Fenêtre d'Arpette is the highest point reached on the Tour of Mont Blanc, and its crossing from Champex is the toughest of the whole route. The statistics of height gain and loss provide a clue as to its strenuous nature, but the reality of this will only be felt on the final approach to the pass where, after negotiating a chaos of boulders, a steep slope of grit ensures that your arrival at the Fenêtre is cause for relief. That being said, the Fenêtre d'Arpette is a true mountain pass and one to enjoy for the sudden extraordinary vision of the upper Trient glacier revealed as you emerge through to the western side. That glacier is on display for most of the descent – that and a long view to the north, which together make the route down one of great beauty.

At the foot of the pass there's a choice of routes to consider. The easiest is to follow a near-level bisse path to the Col de la Forclaz. Or you could shorten Stage 9 by crossing the glacial torrent below the Chalet du Glacier and climbing for 1½hrs to Refuge Les Grands (self-catering accommodation only) or, across the torrent, go down to Le Peuty (30mins) or Trient (45mins). These various options are described in detail below.





Leaving Champex walk up the road to pass the campsite on the right, and shortly after this turn left at a hairpin bend by a café-restaurant into a narrow road (direction Val d'Arpette). Very shortly a signpost directs the TMB to the right, passes beneath a chairlift by a small pond and enters woods. The path joins a *bisse* (irrigation channel), and when it forks you take the left branch, a good contouring path with a fine view through the valley to the right to the distant Dents du Midi. The way continues along the hillside through a forest of spruce and fir with the *bisse* for company, and on coming to a diversion weir, climbs up to a road where you turn right and shortly draw level with the

RELAIS D'ARPETTE (1627m, 45mins) refreshments, 86 dortoir places, 14 beds, camping, open May to end of Oct (Tel 027 783 12 21; info@arpette.ch).

Beyond the hotel the road is unmade, and after passing some chalets overlooking the valley meadows, is no longer drivable. Continue along the ensuing track from which the Val d'Arpette

(20) grows increasingly attractive, and about 30–35mins from the hotel reach a signpost indicating the way to the Fenêtre d'Arpette on a footpath to the right.

At first among trees, this narrow path dodges to and fro across a stream until coming to a more open region, where it begins to climb in earnest through a steep and narrow area. At the top of this bear right at a path junction. The Fenêtre d'Arpette now comes into view as the lowest cut in a skyline crest to the right of some dark spiky crags. The way continues to climb on the north flank of the valley towards its wild upper reaches, and eventually brings you to a chaos of boulders, across which you fight a way to the foot of the final slope. Waymarks and small cairns lead the way across these boulders, but they are not always clearly visible. Great care needs to be taken on this section, for some of the boulders are unstable.

Once across the boulders a steep, gritty slope now rises ahead. Snow patches often lie across this right through the summer, and the path has numerous strands to it. Allow 20–30mins for this final climb, and enjoy a good rest when you arrive at last on the **Fenêtre d'Arpette (2665m, 3½–4hrs)**.



Descending the western side of the Fenêtre – almost as steep as the Arpette side

THE FENÊTRE D'ARPETTE

The Fenêtre is a highlight of the tour in every sense, a window – as its name suggests – onto a new landscape, and is one to savour. The west side of the ridge looks onto the tumbling Trient glacier, spilling its way from the great Plateau du Trient, a 'sweeping snow lake' as it was described by Emile Javelle (in *Souvenirs d'un Alpiniste*). The glacier, now shrinking fast, has carved out a deep valley, the Vallée du Trient (21), which lies far below, and into which the descending path will take you. But when you look back the way you've come, the scene contrasts markedly with that ahead. Here one gazes across a vast slope of scree to bold ridges funnelling the view east and southeast to where the glaciers and snowfields of the Combin massif block the horizon.



The eastern side of the Fenêtre

Through the upthrusting rocks which guard the Fenêtre the marked route swings to the right and descends across a jumble of rocks (caution advised) before settling to a good path that loops down towards the right-hand lateral moraine of the Trient glacier. As mentioned above, this is shrinking fast and now terminates at its icefall, revealing ice-smoothed slabs below where in recent years the glacier lay deep. In places the path drops steeply, then eases to pass the low ruins of Vésevey (2096m). Not long after passing these you come to the first trees, and about 2hrs from the Fenêtre arrive at the *buvette* known as the **Chalet du Glacier (1583m, 5½–6hrs, refreshments)**. A few paces beyond this you'll find a path junction.

Before going further a decision needs to be made in regard to your overnight accommodation. Possibilities are:

- Hotel du Col de la Forclaz (in 45mins) – beds and dortoirs
- Refuge Les Grands – no meals provision (1½hrs)
- Le Peuty for gîte and camping (30mins) and Trient (45mins) for dortoirs.

Much, of course, will depend on your state of fitness after the demands of the route so far. But you'll also need to consider tomorrow's route too, for there's more than one way to reach the Col de Balme on Stage 9. All of the above overnight options are on one route or another to the col, except the Forclaz hotel. Walkers choosing to spend the night there will either return to this junction at Chalet du Glacier or descend to the road near Trient and walk back upvalley. Details will be found under Stage 9.

Route to Col de la Forclaz

Do not cross the torrent, but keep ahead along the easy, near-level path which accompanies the Bisse du Trient (**22**) for about 45mins all the way to the

HOTEL DU COL DE LA FORCLAZ (1526m, 6½hrs) refreshments, shop, bus to Martigny and Trient, accommodation; 40 dortoir places, 35 beds, camping, open mid-Dec to Nov (Tel 027 722 26 88; colforclazhotel@bluewin.ch; www.coldelaforclaz.ch).

Route to Refuge Les Grands

Bear left at the signpost below the Chalet du Glacier, cross the footbridge and turn left on a good path which rises along the wooded hillside. When the path forks take the upper option (the alternative leads to the Alpage des Petoudes). Shortly after this junction the gradient steepens, and the path climbs in zigzags up the west side of the narrow valley falling from the Glacier des

Grands. At the top of the zigzags the way slants to the right and crosses a shelf (safeguarded with fixed cable) against an impressive rock slab, and just above this comes to the

REFUGE LES GRANDS (2113m, 7–7½hrs) 15 dortoir places, cooking facilities, water supply, infrequently wardened (no meals provision); open mid-June to mid-Oct; for reservations (Tel 026 660 65 04).



Refuge Les Grands, a simple but atmospheric place in which to spend a night

Route to Le Peuty and Trient

Cross the footbridge below Chalet du Glacier and turn right on the path which slopes downhill, then onto a narrow tarmac road where you bear left. Before long a footpath on the right enables you to shortcut the road before rejoining it lower down. Now walk along this road across the mouth of the little Nant Noir valley to reach

LE PEUTY (1328m, 6–6½hrs) accommodation at the gîte Refuge Du Peuty: 37 dortoir places, no meals but restaurant in Trient (10–15mins); open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 027 722 09 38); camping nearby.

Continue down the road for a further 10mins to reach

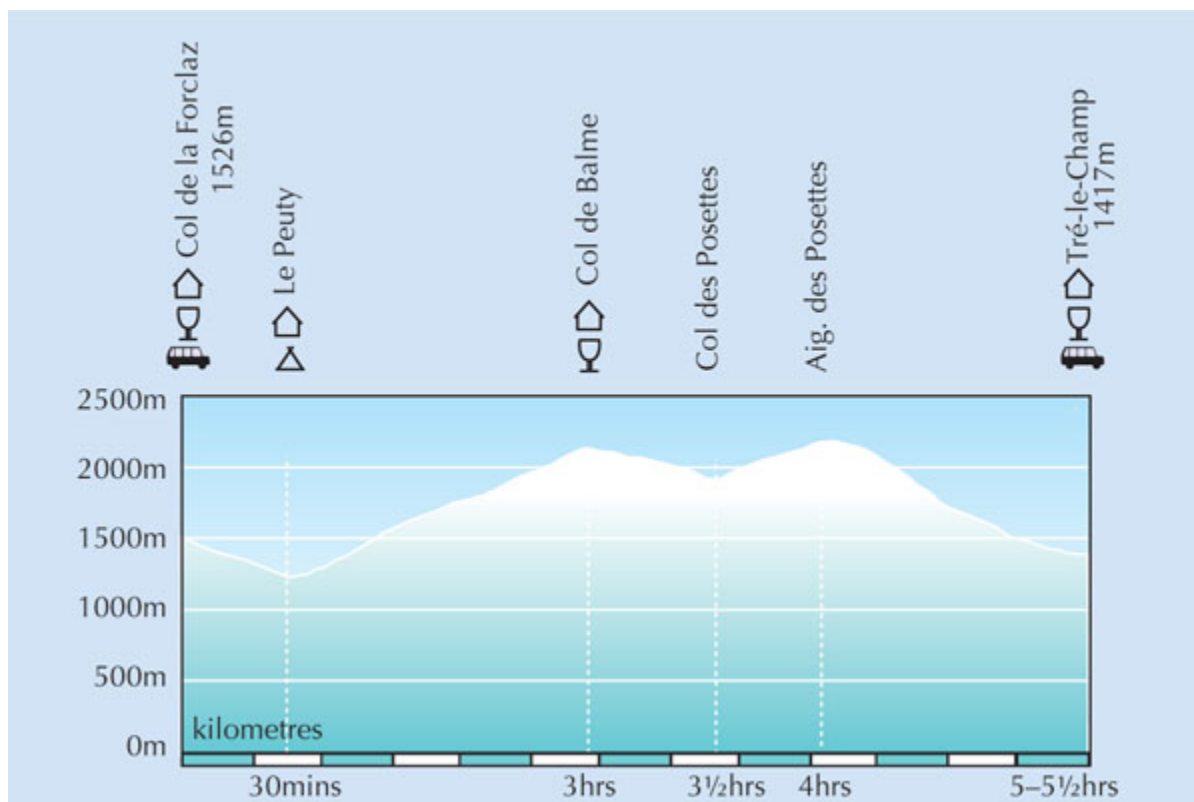
TRIENT (1279m, 6¼–6¾hrs) refreshments, food store, accommodation at: Auberge Mont Blanc, 60 dortoir places, 20 beds, open all year (Tel 027 767 15 05; info@aubergemontblanc.com); La Grande Ourse, 38 dortoir places, 18 beds, plus apartments, open all year (Tel 027 722 17 54; www.la-grande-ourse.ch).

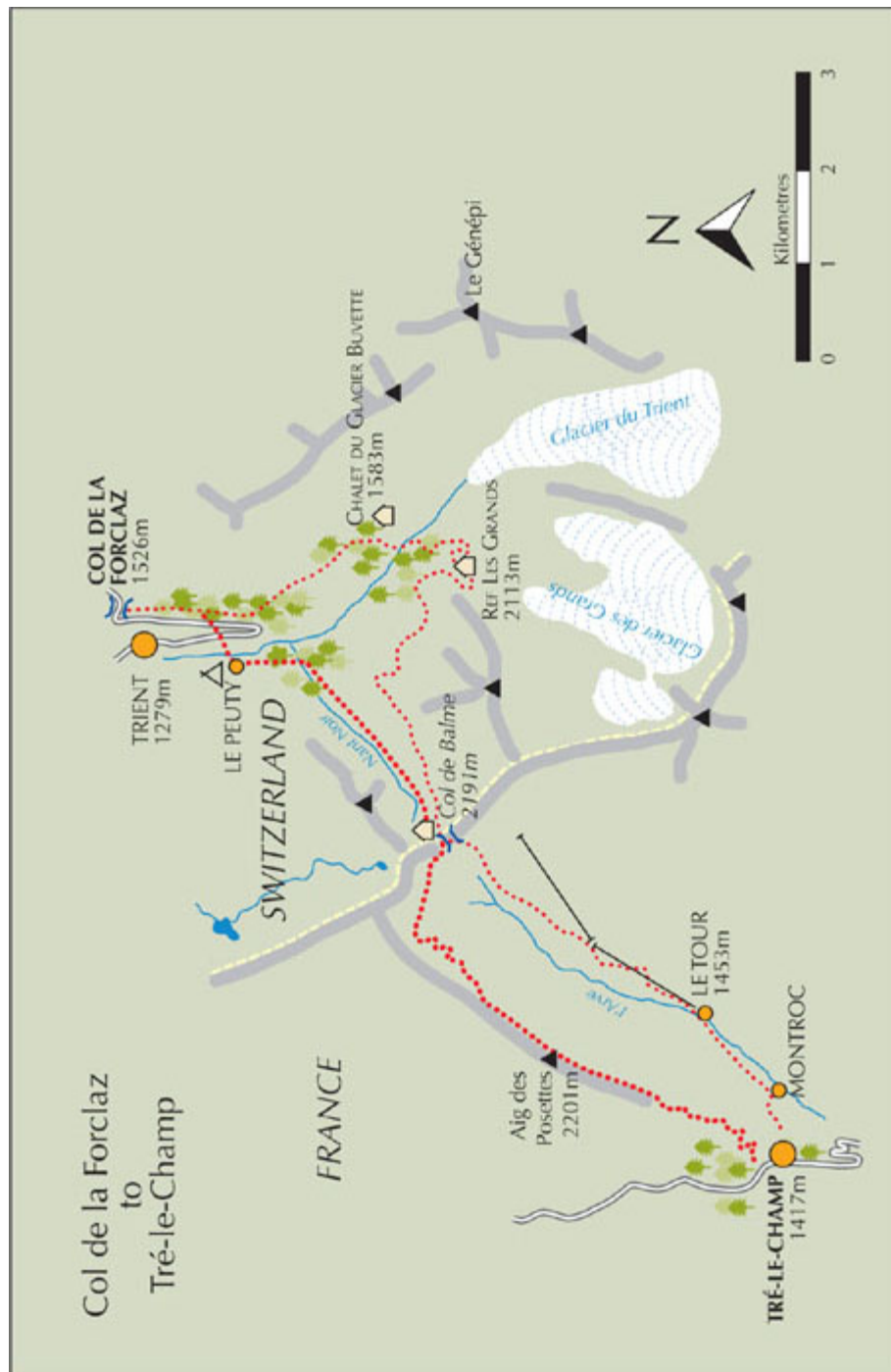
STAGE 9*Col de la Forclaz – Col de Balme – Tré-le-Champ*

Start point	Col de la Forclaz (1526m)
Distance	13km
Height gain	1069m
Height loss	1178m
Time	5½hrs
High point	Aiguillette des Posettes (2201m)
Accommodation	Le Peuty (30mins) – gîte, camping; Col de Balme (3hrs) – refuge; Tré-le-Champ – auberge/gîte
Alternative route	Col de la Forclaz – Les Grands – Col de Balme (see Alternative Stage 9)

Although the accumulated height gain and loss might suggest otherwise, this is not a particularly arduous stage, for the climb to Col de Balme, which accounts for the lion's share of ascent, is mostly achieved at a reasonably benevolent angle, although the second half of the descent from Aiguillette des Posettes is on a steep path that can aggravate tired legs.

Col de la Forclaz marks the northern extent of the TMB, the furthest point from the summit of Mont Blanc, but this stage carries the route over the final mountain barrier and returns it to the Vallée de l'Arve, which flows at the foot of the Monarch of the Alps. As it does, so Mont Blanc reappears, the first time since leaving Rifugio Bonatti at the start of Stage 6. Col de Balme, across which runs the Franco-Swiss border, provides the first view, and the lovely snow dome remains in sight for most of the descent to Tré-le-Champ. This is achieved along the crest of the Aiguillette des Posettes, an elevated path with a huge panorama.





Cross the road in front of Hotel du Col de la Forclaz and follow the path of the Bisse du Trient signed to Chalet du Glacier and Le Peuty. After 8mins take a descending path that twists down the steep wooded slope and brings you onto the road. Turn right and 40m later bear left on a track descending to Trient and

LE PEUTY (1328m, 30mins) accommodation at the gîte Refuge Du Peuty: 37 dortoir places, no meals but restaurant in Trient (10–15mins); open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 027 722 09 38); camping nearby.

From Trient Simply walk up the lower, minor road below the village church for about 15mins to reach Le Peuty.

Immediately south of Refuge Du Peuty veer right on a track signed to Col de Balme, and cutting across the meadows fanning out at the mouth of the Vallon de Nant Noir. On crossing the Nant Noir stream the track becomes a footpath which enters woodland, then climbs in steep zigzags up the south flank of the valley. Eventually the gradient eases and you head to the right across

a more open hillside to the old hutments of Herbagères (2036m, 2½hrs) in a rough hollow. From here the path goes up again with more zigzags to mount the final 150m or so to reach the

REFUGE DU COL DE BALME (2191m, 3hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 26 dortoir places (Tel 04 50 54 02 33).

The refuge enjoys a privileged position on the broad grassy saddle of the Col de Balme **(23)**, which carries the frontier between Switzerland and France. At the col itself two signs give conflicting altitudes: one says 2191m, the other 2204m. There has been a hostelry of some kind here for well over a century, a bone of contention between the two countries, as a result of which it has been burnt down and rebuilt several times. Purchases can be made at the refuge in either Swiss francs or Euros, while the views are magical.



The Aiguilles Verte and Drus demand your attention at the Col de Balme

Note The main route to Tré-le-Champ described below via the Aiguillette des Posettes should not be taken if there is any likelihood of storm. The alternative option is to descend directly from Col de Balme to Le Tour, and thence to Tré-le-Champ by the former TMB path (see box below).

Main Route via Aiguillette des Posettes

Go round to the right (north side) of the refuge and take the path which veers left, crosses onto the French slope and angles round to the right below the Tête de Balme before descending to a farm track and the open saddle of **Col des Posettes (1997m, 3½hrs)**, where there's a multi-junction of paths and a signpost. A track breaks away right to Vallorcine; half-left ahead a shorter low-level route goes to Tré-le-Champ and Col des Montets ([refreshments](#) at the Chalets de Balme). We, however, go straight ahead up a grass slope to pass above a ski tow, making for the crown of the Aiguillette des Posettes. The path has numerous braidings and the slope can be muddy in places where cattle have been grazing, but the way becomes rockier towards the top of the slope.

ALTERNATIVE TMB: COL DE BALME – LE TOUR – TRÉ-LE-CHAMP

Go to the left (south) of the refuge, then veer right at a signpost to descend a good path cutting down the centre of the slope to the middle station of a gondola lift at

CHARAMILLON (1850m), refreshments, accommodation nearby at the Gîte d'Alpage (Les Ecuries de Charamillon), 20 places, open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 54 17 07).

Beyond the lift station continue down to the valley station at

LE TOUR (1453m, 4hrs 20mins), accommodation in Chalet Alpin du Tour [CAF gîte] 87 places, open April to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 54 04 16).

Le Tour is an attractive little village, the highest in the Chamonix valley. From here walk down the road to **Montroc (1354m)**, which you reach in about 18mins, then cut off along a signed path on the right which crosses the railway tunnel and rises to **Tré-Le-Champ (1417m)** in another 15–20mins – a little over 2hrs from Col de Balme.

On gaining the crest the panoramic views are among the best of the walk. There is the rock-cradled Lac d'Emosson off to the right, restrained by its huge dam; the exquisite Aiguille du Chardonnet, Glacier du Tour, Aiguilles Verte and Drus, and the snow dome of Mont Blanc to focus one's gaze ahead and to the left, while alpine flowers and low-growing shrubs occupy crevices in the rocks or claw their way over them.

The path is a good one; it passes the cairn marking the summit of **L'Aiguillette des Posettes (2201m, 4hrs)** half an hour or so after leaving the signpost at the col, then begins the descent. From here to where the route enters forest, the path descends hundreds of timber-braced steps – caution when wet.

About 4–5mins below the Aiguillette come to a junction where the left-hand path angles down to Le Tour. Ignore this and continue ahead, soon descending in zigzags among alpenrose, bilberry and juniper. There are several other path junctions between here and the road below Col des Montets, and at each one you take the right-hand option. The path enters forest and twists its way down to a final T-junction of paths (1435m) a few paces above the road. Turn left here and walk downhill parallel with the road, soon emerging from the trees by a pair of old stone buildings and a small chapel. In another 100m take a stony jeep track sloping downhill on the left, leading to the hamlet of **Tré-le-Champ**.

TRÉ-LE-CHAMP (1417m, 5–5½hrs) accommodation at the charming gîte Auberge la Boerne: 32 dortoir places, open all year (Tel 04 50 54 05 14; contact@la-boerne.fr; www.la-boerne.fr).

Note Should the Auberge be full, the nearest alternative accommodation is at the next hamlet, Les Frasserands (1360m, 15mins) – take the path which descends below Tré-le-Champ. Turn right at a narrow road in the hamlet, then left and follow down to a T-junction. Opposite stands the comfortable gîte Le Moulin, 38 dortoir places, open Dec to end of Sept; (Tel 04 50 54 05 37; benoit.henry2@wanadoo.fr; www.gite-chamonix.com).

A second option is to continue downvalley to Argentière (25mins) by taking the path which accompanies the stream outside the gîte in Tré-le-Champ. Argentière has hotels, a gîte (Le Belvédère), shops, restaurants, PTT, tourist information and bus service to Col des Montets.

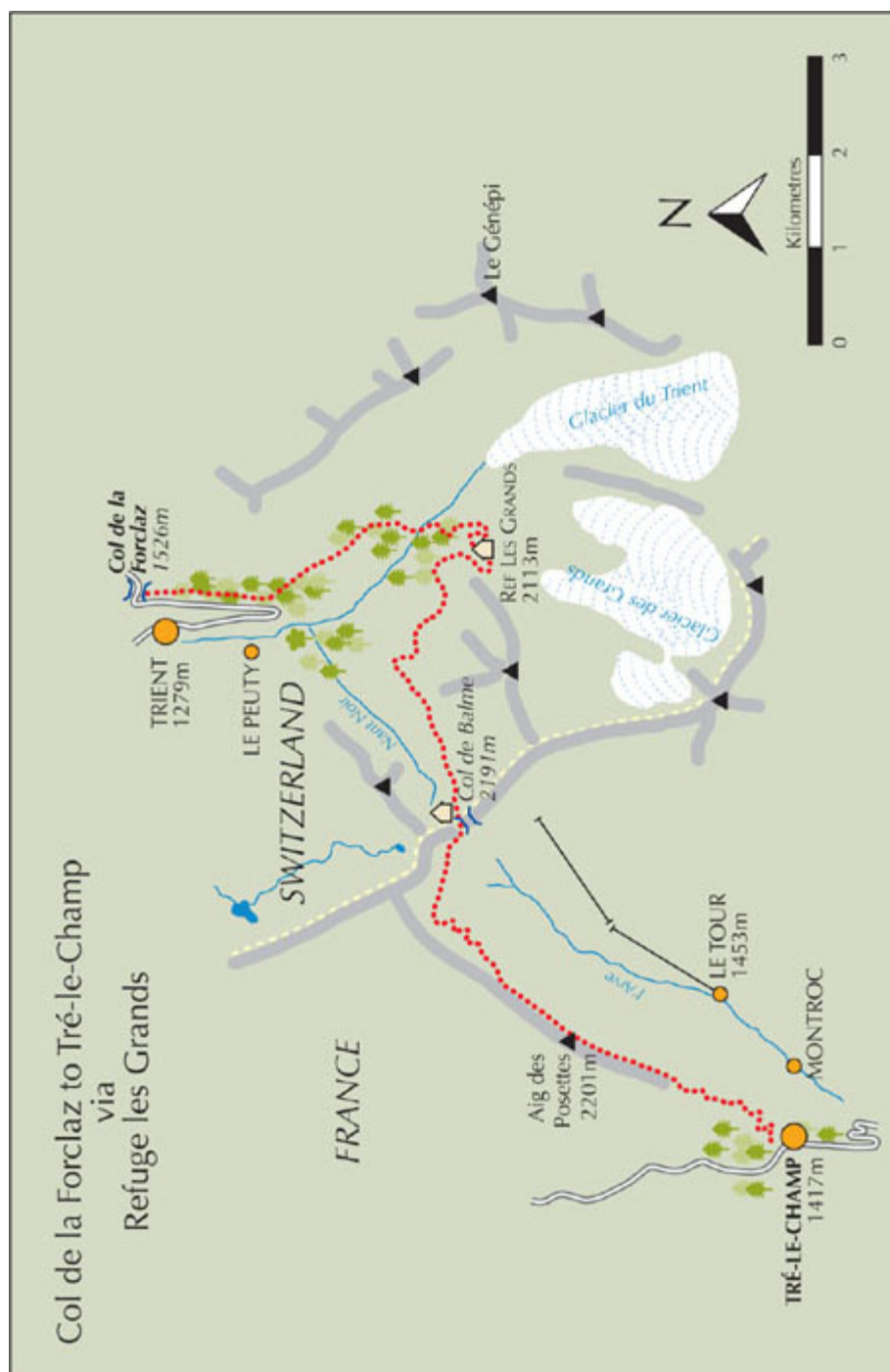
ALTERNATIVE STAGE 9*Col de la Forclaz – Refuge Les Grands – Tré-le-Champ*

Start point	Col de la Forclaz (1526m)
Distance	18km
Height gain	869m
Height loss	978m
Time	6hrs
High points	Col de Balme (2191m) and Aiguillette des Posettes (2201m)
Accommodation	Les Grands (2¼hrs) – CAS refuge (no meals); Col de Balme (3¾–4hrs) – refuge; Tré-le-Champ – auberge/gîte
Alternative route	Col de la Forclaz – Col de Balme direct (see Stage 9)

This TMB *variante* is, in some ways, a better and more varied route than the traditional stage through the Vallon de Nant Noir, although it's more strenuous than at first appears.

The day begins gently enough by following the Bisse du Trient along the wooded hillside to the Chalet du Glacier, then across the glacial torrent to a steep climb leading to the refuge at Les Grands. Above the refuge the path is almost frustratingly undulating – just as you think you've gained sufficient height to be almost at the same altitude as Col de Balme, the way descends, only to climb again. And so it goes on. That having been said, it's a scenic walk across ever-varied terrain, and one less travelled than the standard route. The two ways converge on the Col de Balme.





From the hotel at Col de la Forclaz cross the road and follow the signed path (Chalet du Glacier) which soon joins the Bisse du Trient **(22)** flowing south along the hillside through woodland. About halfway to Chalet du Glacier a clearing allows an unrestricted view through the Vallon de Nant Noir to the refuge on the Col de Balme. After about 45mins you should arrive at the path junction a few paces before the **Chalet du Glacier (1583m, refreshments)**.

Descend to a footbridge spanning the torrent, from which you catch a view up to the Glacier du Trient, and on the far side turn left on a crossing path. This rises along the wooded hillside, gaining height steadily, and then forks. Take the upper path (the alternative leads round to the Alpage des Petoudes) and soon emerge from the pinewoods in the little valley falling from the Glacier des Grands. Passing a few ruins the path now rises more steeply in zigzags, then slants to the right along a shelf tight against an impressive rock slab, the way safeguarded with fixed cable. Across this the path twists uphill again and a few moments later brings you to a group of converted alp buildings, one of which is the

REFUGE LES GRANDS (2113m, 2¼hrs) self-catering accommodation only, 15 dortoir places, cooking facilities, water supply, infrequently wardened, open mid-June to mid-Oct (for reservations Tel 026 660 65 04).

The continuing route to Col de Balme **(23)** leaves at the right-hand (north) end of the buildings, rising diagonally up the slope above the refuge to gain a high point at about 2150m. The path twists among rocks, then eases as a very pleasant balcony among alpenrose and bilberry. While the view ahead is far-reaching and interesting, with the Dents du Midi providing focus, it's worth pausing to enjoy the backward view too. Here the little Glacier des Grands can be seen hanging in its cirque to the south, the larger Trient glacier beyond and to the left of that, while the route from the Fenêtre d'Arpette is easily detected across the valley.

As indicated at the head of this section, the path is an undulating one, and both the scenery and vegetation are delightful all the way. Several minor spurs are turned, which make you think the col is drawing near. Then, angling southwest, the mountainside becomes more stony and, in places, a little thin. Snow patches often lie across the path during the early weeks of the season, in which case caution needs to be exercised when crossing. But eventually the way rises a little, then eases down to a signed junction of paths a few paces from the

REFUGE DU COL DE BALME (2191m, 3¾–4hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 26 dortoir places (Tel 04 50 54 02 33). Views of Mont Blanc and the aiguilles are stunning from here.

The continuing route to **Tré-le-Champ** is described in Stage 9 (above).

STAGE 10

Tré-le-Champ – Refuge La Flégère

Start point	Tré-le-Champ (1417m)
Distance	8km (or 9km via Col des Montets variante)
Height gain	733m
Height loss	257m
Time	3½–4hrs (or 3½–3¾hrs by the variante)
High point	Tête aux Vents (2132m)
Transport option	Bus (Tré-le-Champ – Les Praz de Chamonix); Cablecar (Les Praz – La Flégère)
Accommodation	'Lac Blanc' – refuge; La Flégère – privately-owned refuge
Alternative route	Tré-le-Champ – Col des Montets – La Flégère (see below)

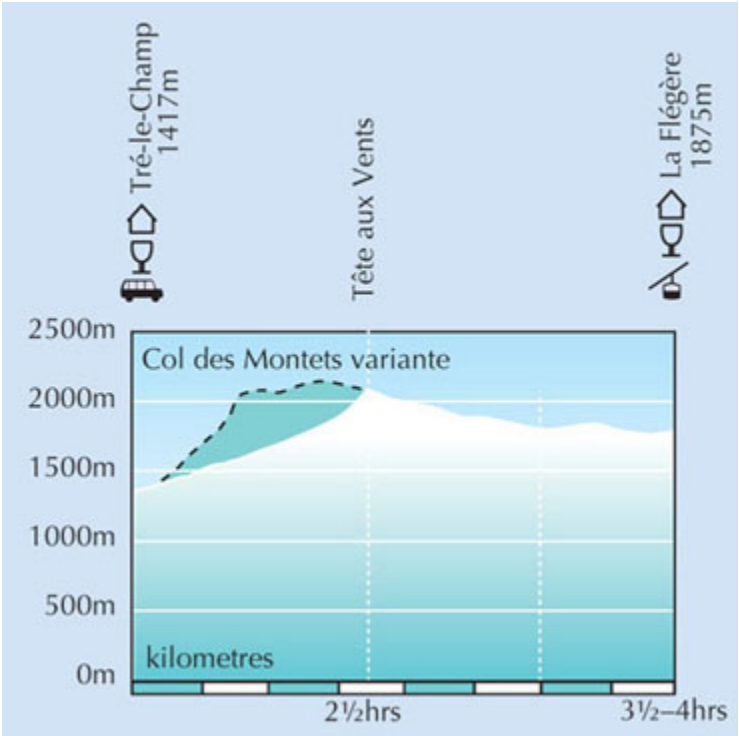
The final two stages of the TMB adopt the highly acclaimed Grand Balcon Sud, one of the most scenic of all alpine belvedere paths, which runs along the mid-height slopes on the north side of the Vallée de l'Arve to provide an almost uninterrupted panorama of the Mont Blanc range. Pray that the weather will be kind enough to allow you to enjoy these stunning views, for they will ensure that your experience of the long circuit will end on a visual high note.

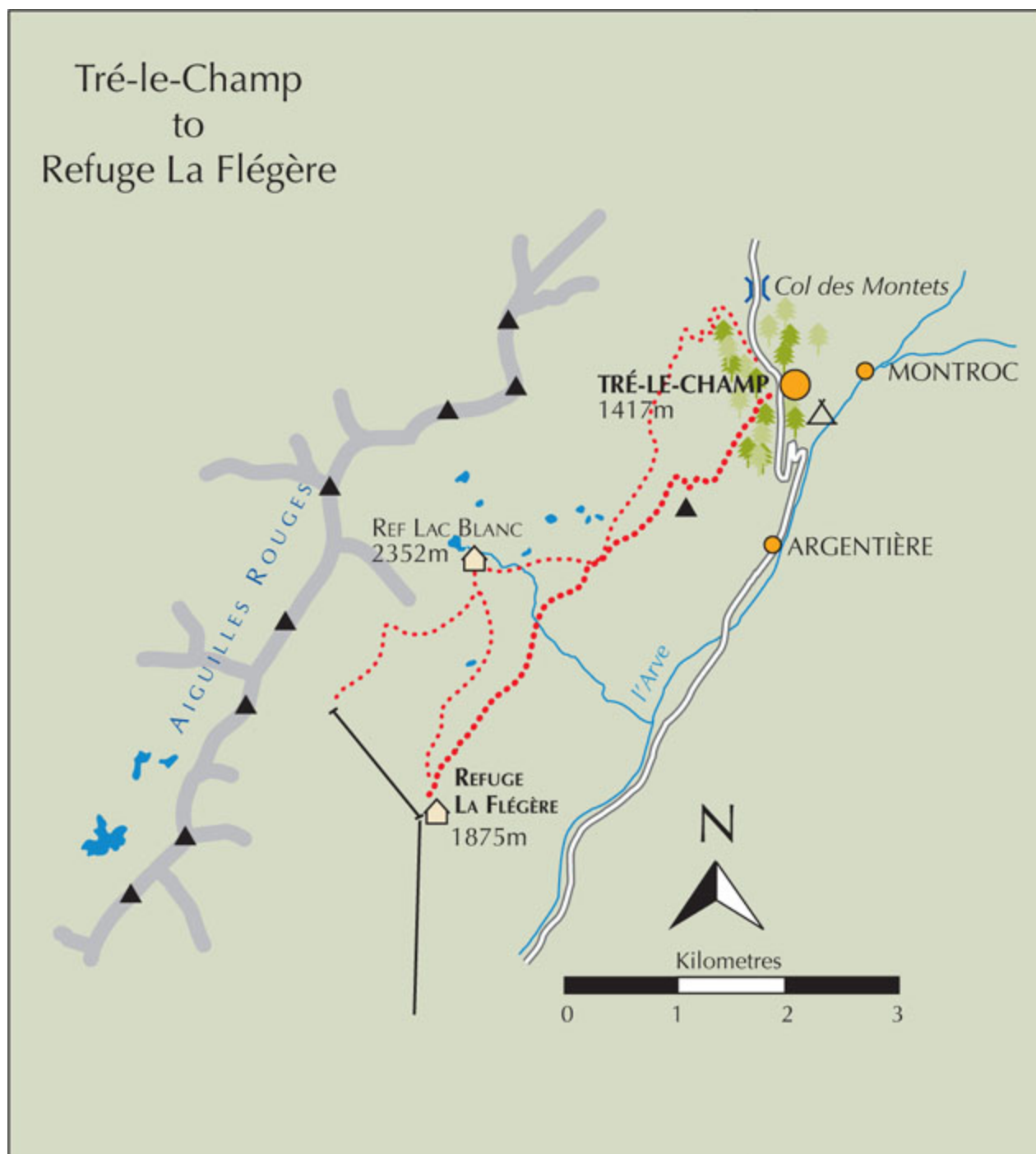
The altitude high point on this particular stage is a large cairn at a junction of paths. The cairn marks a boundary of the Réserve Naturelle des Aiguilles Rouges (24). To reach it by the main route described below entails climbing a series of metal ladders, rungs, platforms and timber steps – the celebrated *passage délicat* – that some walkers may find troublesome, especially those with a tendency towards vertigo. From these artificial aids, which have been provided to overcome steep rock slabs, one gains a sensational bird's-eye view onto the rooftops of Argentière, 800m below.

There is, however, a way to avoid this section, a *variante* which begins further up the road from Tré-le-Champ towards the Col des Montets, and this is also described below (see [Tête aux Vents via Col des Montets](#)).

Another option (accessible from both the ladder route and the Col des Montets *variante*) goes to the famed Lac Blanc, a truly sensational vantage point whose refuge offers alternative overnight accommodation.

Should conditions be too bad to consider any of these options, and you've not enough time in hand to sit and wait a day or two in hope of an improvement, all is not lost. Either walk or take the bus downvalley to Les Praz de Chamonix, and ride the cablecar from there to La Flégère, spend a night in the refuge below the cablecar station, and hope for better weather next day in order to tackle the final stage to Les Houches.





Out of Tré-le-Champ walk up the stony track to the main road, and cross with care to a footpath signed to Lac Blanc, La Flégère and Aiguillette d'Argentière. The way rises among trees and, passing a building, crosses the little Plan de la Grange. Heading southwest and rising all the time, mostly through open woodland, eventually come to a path junction where the left-hand option descends to Argentière. Bear right here and climb more steeply above the treeline towards a line of crags often used by activity centres and climbing schools. The most impressive rock feature is the monolithic Aiguillette d'Argentière, and the TMB path takes you right past its base (1893m).

It is here that you come to the first of the metal ladders and handrails that enable walkers to negotiate a route up the steep rock walls. Although abruptly steep and seemingly endless, this whole series of aids should be perfectly safe – but beware of others climbing above you who may accidentally dislodge stones. Equally important, be careful not to dislodge anything onto anyone below.

At the top of the ladders the path rises again and suddenly comes to the large boundary cairn and path junction at the **Tête aux Vents (2132m, 2hrs)**. The alternative route described in the box above is the path coming from the right (sign for Col des Montets). The path ahead goes to Lac Blanc (see box below) and the Lacs des Chéserys, while we turn left for the Chalet des Chéserys and La Flégère.

TMB VARIANTE: TÊTE AUX VENTS VIA COL DES MONTETS

This route avoids the ladder section leading to the Tête aux Vents. It begins by going up to the main road above Tré-le-Champ, then walking up the road towards Col des Montets. After about 400m take a footpath on the left (1430m) signed Pédestre du Pays du Mont Blanc. Initially this takes you among plants with identification labels, then at a fork you take the left branch (to Lac Blanc and La Flégère), which soon angles north and meets another coming from Col des Montets. Turn left.

The gradient steepens and the path climbs in numerous zigzags to meet its demands, turning outcrops of rock and rising interminably, while views to the south show the first of the Chamonix aiguilles as a hint of even better things to come. At around 2000m the path eases onto a shoulder of hillside marked as La Remouaz on the map. This is where the Grand Balcon Sud officially begins. Now heading southwest the path forks again at 2060m, about 1hr 50mins after leaving Tré-le-Champ. Branch left on the Lac Blanc and Lac des Chéserys path and come to a large cairn at 2053m. Keep left at the next fork (the right branch veers off to the Lacs Chéserys and Blanc, the latter 1hr 20mins from here), and shortly after reach the prominent cairn of **Tête Aux Vents (2132m, 2–2¼hrs)** to join the main route.



One of the many entertaining ladder sections above Tré-le-Champ

LAC BLANC OPTION



Take the path ahead, signed to Lac de Chéserys and Lac Blanc. About 6mins later reach another path junction and turn left. Rising easily at first, the gradient steepens to pass above two of the Lacs de Chéserys, seen below to the right, then up again to cross a rocky knoll beyond which you come to the largest of the Chéserys lakes. Shortly after passing this lake, you come to another ladder-aided section, followed by a series of wood-braced steps before arriving at the privately-owned

REFUGE DU LAC BLANC (2352m, 3hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 40 dortoir places, manned from mid-June to end of Sept (Tel 04 50 53 49 14).

From Lac Blanc, and the tarn behind it, one of the finest of all Alpine views can be enjoyed, for your gaze is directed across the water to the distant Aiguilles Verte and Charmoz, with the glacial highway of the Mer de Glace between them, and the Grandes Jorasses dominating the backing wall; a simply magnificent view.

In order to reach Refuge La Flégère to rejoin the main TMB, cross the lake's outflow stream, pass the old refuge building and bear left. About 6mins below the lake the path forks and you take the left branch. Continuing down there are several other junctions, but at each the way is either clearly signed, or is obvious. Refuge La Flégère, below the cablecar station, is reached in about 1hr 10mins from Lac Blanc.

The panorama that bursts upon you at this cairn is just reward for the effort required to reach it. The whole north flank of the Mont Blanc range is spread out before you, an exquisite line of aiguilles, snow domes and glaciers. It's a view that gradually shuffles and rearranges the prominent players as the walk progresses, and nowhere along the Grand Balcon Sud does that panorama offer anything less than perfection. To quote Alexander Pope: 'And Alps upon Alps arise'.

Main TMB Route to La Flégère

Take the signed path for La Flégère and Chalet des Chéserys, both of which can be seen ahead. The way descends to another junction by the **Chalet des Chéserys (2005m)** in a further 10mins, and continues ahead ignoring alternatives to right and left. Wander across meadows towards a splendid waterfall spraying through a narrow gully in the cliff face on the right. The source of this is the idyllic Lac Blanc. Cross the stream flowing from it, and note that it then spills more cascades down the hillside below the path.

The way continues easily along the hillside with those panoramic views across the valley slowly developing new scenes as you progress. At the skiers' bar-restaurant La Chavanne (closed in summer) the immediate landscape is scarred by pistes, tracks and lifts, and the last few minutes of the walk are along one of these tracks, which takes you to **Refuge La Flégère** immediately below the cablecar station.

REFUGE LA FLÉGÈRE (1875m, 3½–4hrs) accommodation, refreshments; 66 dortoir places, 21 beds; open mid-June to mid-Sept (Tel 06 03 58 28 14; bellay.catherine@wanadoo.fr).

Ignoring the ski-scarred landscape immediately behind the refuge, the view across the valley from the terrace is exquisite and of especial interest to TMB walkers, since it stretches from Col de Balme to Col de Voza. The Mer de Glace basin is directly opposite, flanked by the sharply defined Drus and snow-clad Verte on the left, the Aiguilles des Charmoz and Blaitière on the right. At the far end of the Mer de Glace **(25)** highway stands the solid wall of the Grandes Jorasses. To the right of the Blaitière are the Aiguilles du Plan and Midi, and then the summit of Mont Blanc itself, distinctly visible but perhaps less impressive than its neighbours from this angle, despite the lengthy Bossons glacier which tumbles from it. All in all, the scene is one of bewitching beauty. The refuge is comfortable, and when the cablecars cease for the day and evening settles over the mountains, the ambience is such to make a night spent here a truly memorable one.



Tiny Lac Flégère gives a mirror image similar to that from Lac Blanc

LAC BLANC

After a reasonably short walk to get here it might be worth booking a bed and, leaving your rucksack behind, either walking up to Lac Blanc in about 1½hrs (a height gain of almost 480m) or taking the next stage of the *télécabine* beside the refuge up to l'Index, where an easy and very popular path contours along the hillside and leads directly to the lake. The refuge at the lake provides both refreshments and overnight accommodation (see [Lac Blanc Option](#)), and its situation is justifiably celebrated as having one of the great views of the Mont Blanc range, similar to that from La Flégère but from a loftier perspective and with the bonus of the view being reflected in the lake.

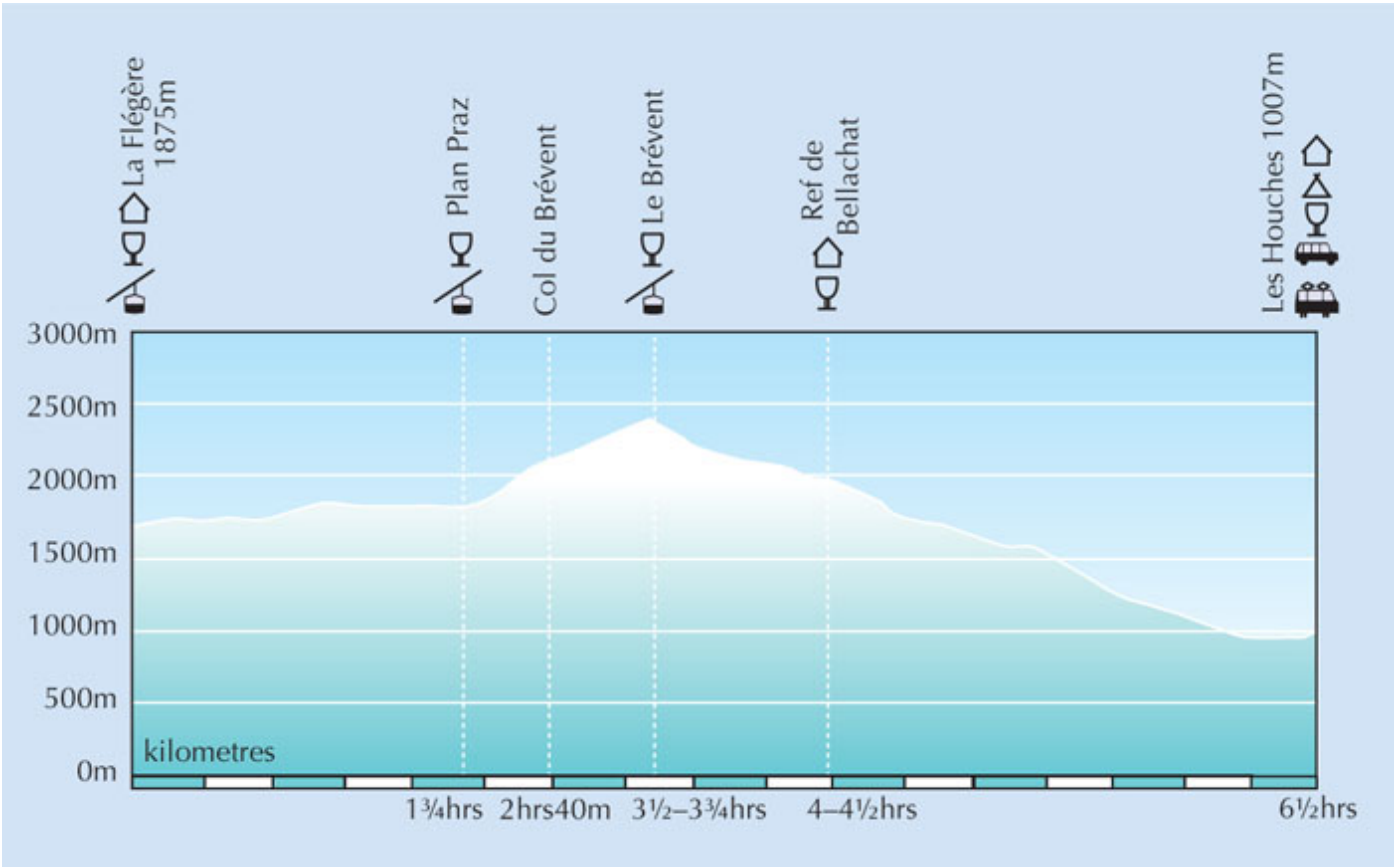
STAGE 11*Refuge La Flégère – Le Brévent – Les Houches*

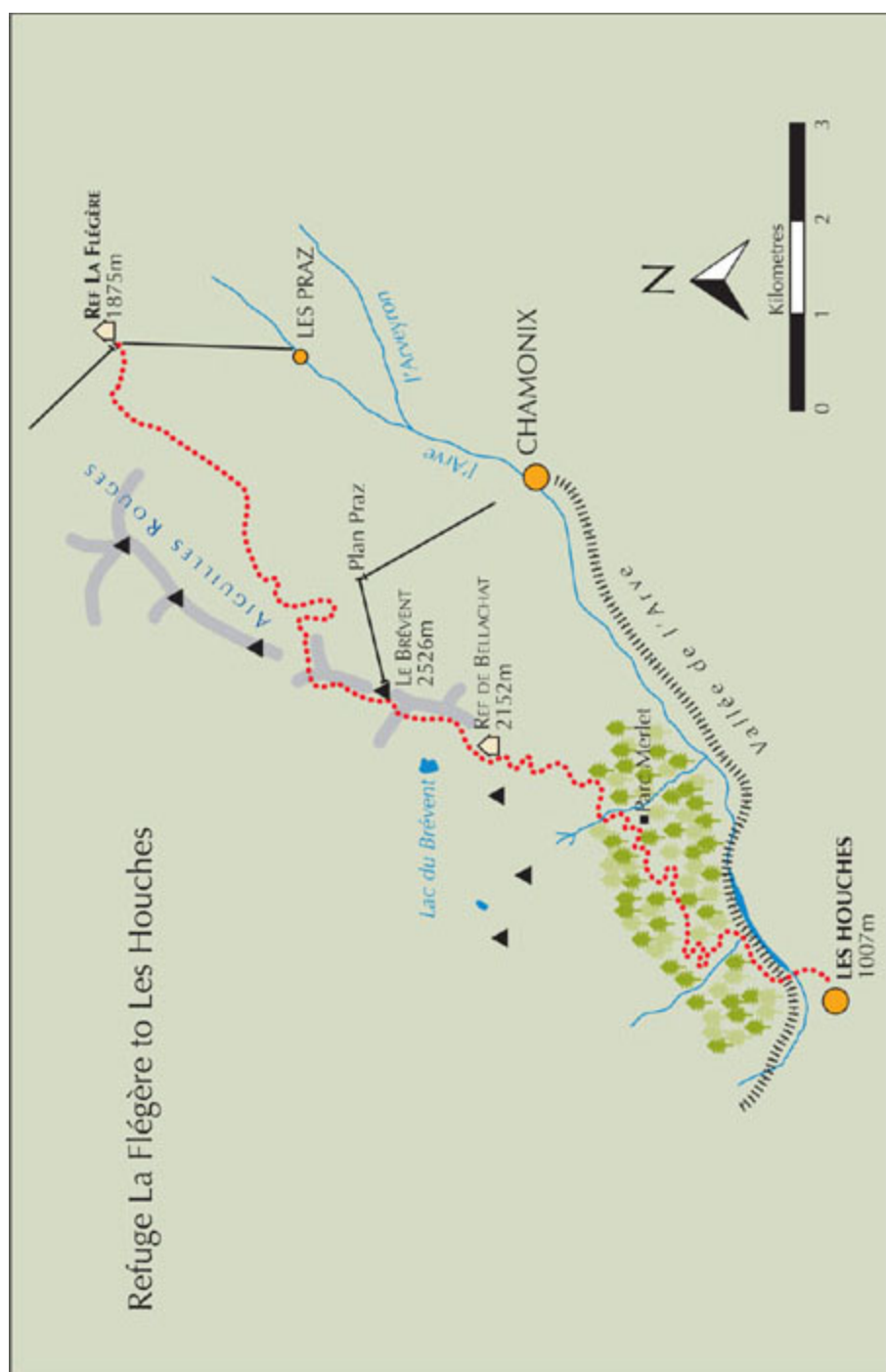
Start point	Refuge La Flégère (1875m)
Distance	17km
Height gain	772m
Height loss	1546m
Time	6½hrs
High point	Le Brévent (2526m)
Transport options	Cablecar (La Flégère – Les Praz de Chamonix); Bus (Les Praz – Chamonix – Les Houches); Cablecar (Le Brévent – Chamonix); Train (Chamonix – Les Houches)
Accommodation	Bellachat (4–4½hrs) – privately-owned refuge; Les Houches – hotels, dortoirs, gîte, camping

The final stage of the Tour of Mont Blanc is as varied as any on this walk. The scenic quality of the route remains unquestionably high, but at Plan Praz, on the way to Col du Brévent, the landscape has been reshaped and badly scarred on behalf of the downhill ski industry, with bulldozed pistes making a mockery of the Alpine environment that was for so long one of its primary appeals. But above this the col opens a window onto a different mountain world, before the TMB dips into a natural wilderness of boulderchoked hollows and limited views, relieved of its ruggedness only when the slope up to Le Brévent has been tackled.

Le Brévent was recognised in the 18th century as being an unrivalled viewpoint from which to study Mont Blanc in all its glory across the valley. The summit is crowned by a small café-snack bar, and a cablecar whisks visitors to within a few metres of the summit. But the visual splendour of that lofty panorama remains as magical as ever.

From here the seemingly never-ending descent to Les Houches is among the steepest and most tiring of the whole circuit, yet the perfect antidote to the walker's inevitable weariness is the constant step-by-step witness to Mont Blanc's unchallenged supremacy as the Monarch of the Alps. If that supremacy was ever in doubt, this final stage of the TMB will surely dispel any previously held scepticism.





Surprising as it may seem, it will take almost 2hrs to reach Plan Praz from La Flégère, most of the way on a very pleasant path which begins by leaving the refuge terrace and cutting across the hillside just below the cablecar station. Shortly after this, fork right on a rising path which soon crosses a short rocky section eased with steps and a handrail. The TMB then makes a fine contour curving round successive hillside bays, one of which is open and rocky, but with masses of bilberries in late summer, before crossing a wooded spur into the open grasslands of **Charlanon (1812m, 50mins)**. Crossing a track the path twists among shrubs and continues straight ahead at a cross-path, then beneath a chairlift and tight against cliffs followed by another contouring path leading to the track once more. Across this the TMB goes up a few steps and continues by making a traverse of the lower slopes of the Clocher de Planpraz before coming to a junction. Walk straight ahead on a broad stony track, rising in a curve across bare open slopes; the complex of lifts and pistes served by the Plan Praz cableway making this (along with the development around La Flégère) the most depressing sight of the whole TMB. But be patient, for once the climb to Col du Brévent gets under way, the worst of it will be behind you.



On the trail from La Flégère to Plan Praz

It's not necessary to go down to the cablecar station and restaurant of **Plan Praz (2000m, 1¾hrs, refreshments)** unless you need their facilities, so follow the track up to the top of a chairlift at 2074m, where there's a sign giving directions to Col du Brévent. Shortly after, take a path on the right which rises gently at first, then more steeply, towards the col. About 20–25mins up this path there's a junction at a bend (2197m). Be certain to turn sharp left here, for the alternative path approaches the Clocher de Plan Praz, which is well away from where we need to go.

Twisting its way upward with a direct view of the abrupt rocky face of Le Brévent, the path needs another 30mins to gain the **Col du Brévent (2368m, 2hrs 40 mins)**. It is on this saddle that the GR5 (La Grande Traversée des Alpes) **(26)** arrives from the Col d'Anterne, which can be seen to the northwest at the right-hand end of the great cliffs of the Rochers de Fiz. A brief rest is called for at the col in order to enjoy the contrasting views to north and south, because very shortly you will enter an enclosed hollow where your field of vision is severely restricted. Bouquetin (ibex) are known to inhabit this upper region, so keep alert for a possible sighting.

Now the TMB veers left and rises a little to enter a secluded basin where snow often lies in pockets well into the summer. In this wilderness of rocks and boulders the way is guided by an assortment of cairns and red spots, as well as the standard red–white waymark stripes. Climbing out of this hollow, two steel ladders and metal handrails aid the ascent of a steep section which might otherwise be a little tricky for those carrying a big rucksack. Then come onto a track/piste which rises up the northern slope of Le Brévent, with a view into the Diosaz valley and the distant Chaîne des Aravis, on the way passing a small col on the left where a direct but less interesting route from Plan Praz emerges. Shortly after this reach another junction on a shoulder just below the Brévent summit. Although it's not essential to do so, if the weather is fine it would be difficult to resist the 5min diversion required to visit the top of this well-known mountain.



Le Brévent has long been famed for its direct view of Mont Blanc

Le Brévent (27) (2526m, 3½–3¾hrs, refreshments) provides an amazing full-frontal view of Mont Blanc, and an aerial perspective of Chamonix **(28)** lying almost 1500 vertical metres below – a sight almost as riveting as that of the glaciers opposite. In addition to the summit terrace with its modest café-bar, there's another restaurant at the head of the cableway just below the top.



Refuge de Bellachat

Between the summit and the railway at Les Houches almost every step will now be downhill, a knee-wrenching, wearisome – but spectacular – descent, almost all the way on a good, if steep, path. From the junction just below the summit the TMB is signed to Bel Lachat. It descends in zigzags along little crests and into a rocky landscape which is left by a gap in its low enclosing ridge. There's nothing difficult about the route, and soon you can relax to enjoy the panorama, which should still have the power to excite as you wander down to grass slopes and, about 50mins or so from Le Brévent, come to a path junction on a grassy bluff. Just to the left, and tucked against the hillside, stands the

REFUGE DE BELLACHAT (2152m, 4–4½hrs) refreshments, accommodation, 28 dortoir places, open late-June to mid-Sept (Tel 04 50 53 43 23).

The outlook here is almost as magical as that from Le Brévent. Hogging the view is the long trunk of the Bossons glacier, which is seen full-length from top to bottom in all its rippled

splendour across the way. Unless you have good reason to continue down to Les Houches or Chamonix, an overnight spent in this idyllic location is highly recommended.



Morning light throws shadows from the Chamonix aiguilles; the scene below Refuge de Bellachat

The path now descends to the right of the refuge, soon dropping in a series of zigzags down the precipitous flank of the Aiguillette de Brévent. The way descends into patches of forest and angles round to the right to the Vouillard's ravine which has a stream running through it. This is gained by way of several metal steps with handrails for security. Across the stream the path soon takes you into forest again on the edge of the Parc Merlet mountain zoo **(29)**. Waymarks around the zoo's perimeter fence indicate the route to the zoo's access road.

Follow this road to the right for a short distance away from the parking area, then take a path on the left which brings you quickly down to a good contouring section in woodland once more. Signs to follow at junctions are for Christ Roi and/or Les Houches, and about 20mins after leaving the zoo car park you arrive at the base of the towering concrete statue of Christ the King, or **Le Christ Roi (30) (1196m, 6hrs)**.

A series of footpath shortcuts circumvents the track, which sweeps down to the valley in long loops, through forest almost all the way, until shortly before coming to the road that leads to the railway station below **Les Houches**, where the TMB began nearly two weeks and a host of memories ago. *Now's the time to celebrate. You've earned it – congratulations!*

An extract from **Tour of Mont Blanc**

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